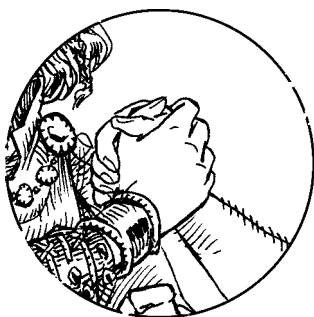

Playing the Game



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Playing the Game



This chapter is addressed to players, but the GM should read it too!

The conversation

You play *Stonetop* by talking to each other. The GM says something, you and the other players respond. You ask each other questions. You refer to the rules, roll some dice, and talk about what the results mean. You take turns talking, but it's not, like, *taking turns*. As with any conversation, you'll talk over each other, interrupt, offer suggestions, and so forth.

The goal of this conversation is to create **the fiction**, the shared imaginary reality in which the characters exist and act. The specifics of the fiction are often fuzzy, with each of you picturing things differently. But when the details start to matter, you'll talk it out, clarify the situation, and come to an agreement.

As a player, **you are responsible for your player character** (your PC). What they say and what they do. How they feel. Their background and their experiences prior to play. You speak in your PC's voice. You say what your PC does.

The GM is responsible for everything else, including:

- ⊙ The world, the terrain, the weather
- ⊙ Monsters and hazards
- ⊙ Non-player characters (NPCs),
- ⊙ What happened before the PCs got here
- ⊙ What happens after they leave

The GM will ask for input and ideas. They'll ask you to make up details about the world that your PC would know. But ultimately, the world beyond the PCs is the GM's domain. The GM describes how the world reacts to the PCs' actions, and they curate what is and isn't true about the world at large.

Your agenda

When you play *Stonetop*, these should be your goals:

- ⊙ Portray a compelling character
- ⊙ Engage with the fictional world
- ⊙ Play to find out what happens

The game's rules and structure assume that you are pursuing these three goals, and no others. This isn't a game that you play to win. The game doesn't expect you to optimize your character. It's not a game about testing your skill, and it's not a game where you show up to be led through the GM's story.

Your first and most important goal is to **portray a compelling character**. Your PC is one of the protagonists of the story. Make them worthy of that role. Don't treat them as just a set of stats and abilities. Portray them as a person, with hopes and dreams, inner conflicts, and relationships with others. Your **playbook** (page 50) will help you to sketch out a compelling character, but it's your job to bring that character to life, to portray a protagonist that you and your fellow players care about.

Your second goal is to **engage with the fictional world**. Don't just react to the world that the GM presents, care about it. Explore it and be curious about it. Talk with NPCs like they're real people, get invested in their stories. And don't just allow the world to be revealed to you—contribute! Suggest details. Ponder out loud about what things might mean. Be a fan of the world that you and the GM and your fellow players are creating together.

The GM's agenda

In case you're wondering, the GM's agenda is as follows:

- ⊙ Portray a rich, mysterious world
- ⊙ Punctuate the PCs' lives with adventure
- ⊙ Play to find out what happens

In other words, they're supposed to present you with a world that's worth engaging with. They're meant to present opportunities and threats and challenges to your PCs and the things they care about. And then—just like you—they're meant to let the game unfold and find out what happens as a result.

For more on the GM's agenda, see page 168.

Finally, **play to find out what happens**. The rules and the dice are there to introduce uncertainty and surprises, to tell us what happens when things go wrong. Your character won't always get what they want. You often won't get what you expect.

Have ideas for your character's arc and story, sure, but hold those ideas lightly. We don't yet know what your PCs' story will be, whether it will be a comedy or a tragedy or a little bit of both. Play to find out what happens.

Flow of play

The GM establishes the situation: where you are, what time it is, who's there, what's going on. They describe the environment, add details, and portray NPCs. They ask questions about what you're doing or what's on your mind.

As a player, you ask questions to clarify and understand the situation. You answer the GM's questions. You offer up details or ideas of your own. Maybe you all act out a bit of dialogue.

Once the situation is established, the GM says something to **provoke action** and/or **increase tension**. Then they ask, "**What do you do?**"

If you...

... need more information, **ask for it**.

... **trigger a player move** (page 207), follow the move's procedures.

... **do anything else**, the GM says what happens.

If you **ignore an established danger**, or you trigger a move and **roll a 6 or less**, the GM says what bad thing happens.

The process then repeats. The GM re-establishes the situation, gives it a nudge, and asks, "What do you do?"

When the current situation ends, the GM frames the next one. If they're unsure what situation should come next, they'll ask you and your fellow players questions until it becomes clear.

The flow of play is conversational. **There are no formal turns**, not even during fights. The GM is responsible for moving the spotlight around, addressing one PC at a time and ensuring that you each have a chance to talk and act. But it's okay to interject, make suggestions, or jump in and say what you're doing before the GM asks. **Just be polite and respectful and share the spotlight** with your fellow players.

The conversation and the game will shift naturally between **scenes** and **loose play**. Scenes happen in a specific place at a specific time, with players speaking in their PC's voices and saying what they're doing moment-by-moment. Loose play is zoomed out, less specific, taking place over time and space. When you explore the clearing where Pryder went missing, looking for clues and discussing what you've found, that's a scene. When you spend the rest of the day following his trail through the woods—discussing how long you want to keep going and what you're each doing to get on each other's nerves—that's loose play.

Dice and moves

As you all talk about what's happening in the fiction, and what your PCs are doing, you'll often trigger **moves**. A move is a little bit of rules that shapes the conversation and the fiction.

Here's an example:

CLASH

When you *fight in melee or close quarters*, roll +STR: **on a 10+**, your maneuver works as expected (deal your damage) and pick 1:

- ⊙ Avoid, prevent, or counter your enemy's attack
- ⊙ Strike hard and fast, for 1d6 extra damage, but suffer your enemy's attack

On a 7-9, your maneuver works, mostly (deal your damage), but you suffer your enemy's attack.

Many moves are shared by all players (see page 207). Other moves are specific to your **playbook** (page 50), an **insert** (page 57), or an **arcaneum** (page 58). Other moves will be custom-made for specific situations (page 234).

Triggers

Each move has a **trigger**, which says when the move kicks in. The trigger is almost always fictional; you say that your character does something that matches the trigger, and the rest of the move tells us how to resolve that action.

You might trigger a move intentionally, describing actions that you know match its trigger. Or you might say, "I Clash." That's fine, but expect the GM to ask you what that looks like, or what exactly you're doing to meet the move's trigger. **To do it, you have to do it.**

The opposite is also true: **if you do it, you have to do it.** If you elbow this guy in the face, and we all agree that you're *fighting in close quarters*, then that's Clash. You can back out ("Oh, no, I don't elbow him after all"), but if you carry on, make with the dice.

It's everyone's job to watch for moves. If you think you've triggered a move, say so. If another player triggers a move and no one notices, say something! "Hey, elbowing a guy in the face sounds like 'fighting in close quarters,' is this Clash?"

Everyone must agree that you're doing something plausible and that the trigger is actually met. For example:

- ⊙ If the guy is 12 feet tall and holding you at arm's length, then his face isn't close enough to elbow! Do something else.
- ⊙ If the guy is literally made of iron, an elbow to his face won't do squat and Clash doesn't trigger. If you insist on trying, the GM says what happens.
- ⊙ If the guy is distracted and doesn't see it coming, then you're not really *fighting* and Clash doesn't trigger. You just bash his face and the GM says what happens next.

If it's unclear whether you're triggering a move, or which one you're triggering, talk it out. Clarify your intent and the details until everyone agrees.

Playing the Game

Rolling

Many moves tell you to “roll +STAT” (usually with a specific stat, like STR or INT, see page 52).

“Roll” means: roll two six-sided dice (2d6), and add them together.

“+STAT” means: find that stat in your PC’s playbook and add it to the roll. Stats range from -1 to +3.

For example: I say that I elbow this guy in the face. We agree that I’m *fighting in close quarters*, triggering Clash. I roll 2d6 and add my PC’s STR. If my STR is +1, my roll might look like this:

$$\text{Die 1} + \text{Die 2} + \left[\begin{array}{c} \text{Strength} \\ +1 \\ \text{(STR)} \end{array} \right] = 8$$

You’ll sometimes have **advantage**, meaning: roll an extra die and discard the lowest. With the advantage of an extra die, the roll above might look like this:

$$\text{Discard} + \text{Die 1} + \text{Die 2} + \left[\begin{array}{c} \text{Strength} \\ +1 \\ \text{(STR)} \end{array} \right] = 10$$

And sometimes, you’ll have **disadvantage**: roll an extra die and discard the highest. With disadvantage, that roll might look like this:

$$\text{Die 1} + \text{Discard} + \text{Die 2} + \left[\begin{array}{c} \text{Strength} \\ +1 \\ \text{(STR)} \end{array} \right] = 7$$

If you have advantage and disadvantage on the same roll, they cancel each other out. Roll normally (2d6, add them).

Advantage and disadvantage normally stem from a move or condition. The GM can apply them ad hoc if they deem a roll especially hard or easy, but they’re encouraged not to. See page 74.

Results

When a move has you roll, it will also say what happens based on that roll.

On a 10+ (meaning, a total roll of 10 or higher), you get a **strong hit**, the best you can hope for.

On a 7-9 (meaning, a total roll of 7, 8, or 9), you get a **weak hit**. You get only some of what you wanted, or you get what you wanted but with a cost.

On a 6- (meaning, a total roll of 6 or lower), you get a **miss**, which entails these effects:

- ⊗ **You mark XP** (page 53), unless the move says otherwise
- ⊗ **The GM says what happens**, and it will be bad

A 6- doesn’t always mean you screwed up.

It means something bad happens, something that your PC won’t like. Your foe gets the jump on you. The branch breaks before you can jump. You find the missing villager, but oh no, they’ve been dead for hours.

A few moves say what happens on a 6-, in which case the GM must abide by those results. But for most moves: **on a 6-, mark XP and prepare for the worst.**

If a move doesn’t have you roll, then it will just tell you what happens.

Whatever the results of a move, work together to **figure out what it looks like in the fiction**. The GM has final say on how the world reacts to and is affected by your actions, but they are constrained by the results of your move and they might very well ask you for input.

You and your fellow PCs have entered the cave bears' den, hoping to harvest some much-needed meat during a long, hard winter. You're playing Caradoc (the Would-be Hero).

"Caradoc," says the GM, "your eyes are adjusting to the gloom when you hear snuffling, and the sound of something moving, something big. At the edge of the light, a huge form rears up and ROARS. It's a bear, what do you do?"

"Here we go," you say. "I yell and rush it, shield up, stabbing with my spear."

"That sure sounds like you're fighting in melee with this 10-foot-tall bear. Roll +STR to Clash!"

You get lucky and roll a 4 and a 5. With your STR +1, that's a 10! You (perhaps unwisely) choose to strike hard for extra damage, but suffer its attack in turn. You deal 6 damage total, not bad! You and the GM agree that this means your strike landed and you bloodied the big beast.

But you also suffer its attack. The GM says "As you connect, it just THWAPS you with its right paw. Take 1d10+4 damage. Roll it." You take 9 damage (almost half your hit points). The GM says, "I think you get your shield up but the force of the blow smacks it into your head, and sends you staggering back. Mark the dazed debility, as the world starts spinning."

If you had rolled a 6 or less, then the GM probably would have said that the bear thrwacked you (as above) before you were able to stab it. But, hey, at least you would have gotten to mark XP.

Hold and spend

Some moves will tell you to "hold x currency," where the currency is something specific like "Preparation" or "Readiness." Note how much you hold, and spend it as described by the move.

For example:

DEFEND

When you **take up a defensive stance** or **jump in to protect others**, roll +CON: **on a 10+**, hold 3 Readiness (or 4 if you bear a shield); **on a 7-9**, hold 1 Readiness (or 2 with a shield). You can spend Readiness 1-for-1 to:

- ⊙ Suffer an attack's damage/effects instead of your ward
- ⊙ Halve an attack's effect or damage
- ⊙ Draw all attention from your ward to yourself
- ⊙ Strike back at an attacker (deal your damage, with disadvantage)

When you **go on the offense, cease to focus on defense, or the threat passes**, lose any Readiness that you hold.

Think of held currency as permission to do something awesome, now or later. When you spend held currency to do something, you just do it—even if it interrupts the flow of play, and even if doing it would normally trigger a move. If you spend 1 Readiness to strike back at an attacker and deal some damage, you just do that, even though fighting in melee would normally trigger Clash.

When you spend currency, say what it looks like in the fiction. If you can't describe it, then don't spend the currency after all.

Playing the Game

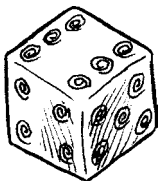
The GM, dice, and moves

In *Stonetop*, the GM doesn't normally roll dice and they don't trigger moves. If you're fighting a monster, the GM might declare, "It leaps at you, claws out and hissing." But they don't trigger Clash and they don't roll dice to see if the monster's attack succeeds. Instead, they ask, "What do you do?"

If you ignore the leaping monster, then the GM will confirm that you understand the situation and really want to do that. If you do, they'll tell you what bad thing happens as a result.

More likely, you'll do something about this monster leaping at your face: you duck and hope it flies over you, or twist away and stab it, or raise your shield to block it. This will probably trigger a move, and the result of that move will inform whether or not the monster's attack lands.

For more details, see the **Running the Game** chapter (page 167). For more on fights specifically, see **Running combat** (page 406).



The Die of Fate

When the GM wants to let the fates decide an outcome, but there's no move that would apply, they might ask you to roll the Die of Fate. That means: roll a d6 (straight, with no modifiers unless the GM says otherwise). High is good, low is bad.

Fictional positioning

The actions that your character takes and the moves you trigger are informed by your fictional positioning—the sum of established fictional details about your character and the world around them. This includes (but is not limited to):

- ⊙ Your established traits (age, height, weight, experiences, skills, habits, instincts, personality, etc.)
- ⊙ Your equipment, what you have in hand vs. stowed away, what's on your person, what's within reach
- ⊙ Your position, relative to your foes, your allies, hazards, cover, features of the environment
- ⊙ What you can realistically see or hear or otherwise sense, given the light, your position, the weather
- ⊙ What you're doing, what you're looking for, what you're focused on
- ⊙ Your momentum, your footing, your balance, your emotional state
- ⊙ How you describe doing something, your approach to the challenge at hand

Your fictional positioning determines what actions are feasible, whether your action triggers a move, and which move that action triggers. It affects the range of possible outcomes for a move, both good and bad.

In many role-playing games, your fictional positioning results in bonuses or penalties to your rolls, or changes the number you're trying to roll over or under. It adjusts the probability of a roll succeeding or not. That's not really a thing in *Stonetop*. You don't get a +1 bonus or -1 penalty just because the GM deems a task to be "easy" or "hard."

Instead, your fictional positioning might be reflected by...

... **how much of a spot the GM puts you**

in before asking, “What do you do?”

“The drake hisses and tenses, like it’s about to charge, what do you do?” vs.

“There’s a rustling to your left and something big bursts out of the brush, coming right at you, what do you do?”

... **whether your action is even feasible.**

“The cliff is pretty sheer, and wet, and your fingers are already numb from the cold. I don’t think you can just climb it.”

... **whether a move is triggered, or if you**

just do what you wanted. “No, don’t roll to Clash, you’ve caught him flat-footed. Just deal your damage.”

... **whether a move even *can* trigger.** “You

can stab it with your spear, but that won’t trigger Clash. It’s made of solid stone. You won’t hurt it, you’ll just put yourself in danger. You sure?”

... **what’s required to attempt an action, and/or to trigger a move.** “No way you

can make that jump right now. You need to drop down to a light load first, and even then you’ll be Defying Danger.”

... **which move is triggering.** “No, I don’t

think you’re Seeking Insight, I think you’re Defying Danger with WIS to spot them in time.”

... **the risks being lesser or greater.** “In

this case, suffering his attack will mean he just gets inside your guard.” Or, “Just to be clear, if you roll a 6-, you’re gonna miss the jump and you’ll be rolling for Death’s Door.”

... **the scope of what a single move can**

accomplish. “Cool, a 10+? Yeah, you

get to Andras, arrows whizzing past you, and manage to drag him to cover.”

Or, “Okay, cool, but I think that’s two moves—Defy Danger to duck inside its guard, and then Clash if you manage to pull that off. Do you still do that?”

... **rarely, whether you make a roll with**

advantage or disadvantage. “Oof, with

the gusting wind, I don’t think the shot is impossible but it’ll be particularly

hard. You can Let Fly, but you’ll have

disadvantage on the roll.” The GM

should do this rarely, though, because

it diminishes the impact of moves and

other mechanics that specifically apply advantage or disadvantage.

PC vs. PC

There will be times when you and other

PCs come into conflict. You might **Per-**

sue (page 226) another PC to go along

with your plan. They might **Seek Insight**

(page 228) to figure out what you’re up to.

You might **Interfere** (page 218) to keep

them from doing something they’ll regret, or something *you’ll* regret.

When there’s conflict between PCs, slow

down. If you’re making a move that tar-

gets another PC, or that you think another

PC might object to, give them a chance to

say what *they’re* doing, what move (if any)

they make.

If another PC does something that you

want to Interfere with, speak up! Raise

your hand or interrupt. Say how you try to

stop what they’re doing.

If it’s unclear who is triggering which

moves, and in what order, talk it out. The

GM has the final say.

Your principles

As a player, *Stonetop* works best if you...

- ⊙ Begin and end with the fiction
- ⊙ Connect with the other PCs
- ⊙ Show us what's important to you
- ⊙ Have goals and pursue them
- ⊙ Be bold, take risks
- ⊙ Embrace difficulty, setback, and failure
- ⊙ Participate in worldbuilding
- ⊙ Build on what others have said
- ⊙ Give others a chance to shine
- ⊙ Participate in the conversation

Following these principles will lead you to achieving your **agenda** (page 37). Strive to follow them, always.

Begin and end with the fiction

Tell us how you do what you do, what it looks like. Don't just say "I'm Seeking Insight," tell us *how*. "I cock my head, listening to the sounds of the forest for anything odd." Don't just say "I attack," say *what you do*. "I rush in, shield up, stabbing into this thing's gut."

When you resolve a move, make sure you're clear about what has happened as a result. It's the GMs job to describe the impact of your move on the world (or to defer to you). If they skimp, or think things are clear when they aren't, then say so. If you can't picture what happened, ask for more detail!

Beginning and ending with the fiction is one of the main ways that you **engage with the fictional world**. But it's also a great way to **portray a compelling character**. Anyone can trigger Clash, but show us how *you*, Brynfor of Stonetop, fight this particular fight.

Connect with the other PCs

Explore the relationships between your character and the other PCs. Play out scenes with each other, speaking in your character's voices. Go out of your way to interact with each other, to care about each other, and to get involved in each other's lives.

Your PCs don't have to be *friends*. They don't even have to like each other. But the game assumes that they're allies at least, and that they'll work together on behalf of the town when there's trouble. Your PCs will spend a lot of on-screen time together.

When you develop nuanced relationships with your fellow PCs, and let those relationships change and grow, you are **portraying a compelling character**. When you let those relationships guide your actions and your decisions, even if it means bringing you into conflict with each other, you are **playing to find out what happens**.

Show us what's important to you

Ask yourself, as your character: Who and what will you fight for? What do you prize? What do you aspire to, hope for, dream of? For whom would you lay down your life?

Make it clear what you value, through word and deed, and you'll be **portraying a compelling character**. Show yourself caring about mundane things like your home and your garden and your goats, about NPCs and what they think of you, and you'll be **engaging with the fictional world**. Let your values guide your actions and push you into conflict, and then **play to find out what happens**.

Have goals and pursue them

Identify things that your PC wants—a steading improvement, an NPC's hand in marriage, the respect of the elders, maybe just a roof that doesn't leak—and actively work towards those things in play. Don't just react to the threats that the GM presents. Having goals and striving towards them is a great way to **portray a compelling character**, and it pretty much requires you to **engage with the fictional world**.

But also: have goals as a player. Share these goals with the GM and the other players. Have meta-game conversations about scenes that you want to have and conflicts you want to play towards. Just as important, be clear about what's not important to you, what you'd be happy glossing over. Your play time is limited, so be clear about what you want to see in the game. The **End of Session** move (page 232) gives you a formal chance to do this, but you can always step out of character and talk to each other, player-to-player.

To be clear: having goals and pursuing them doesn't mean "always getting what you want." It means having things that you work towards, things that will drive scenes and adventures. Whether you achieve your goals is up to the actions you take and the moves you trigger and the dice you roll, and how the fiction logically and plausibly reacts. **Play to find out what happens.**

Be bold, take risks

Take decisive action that moves the game and situation forward. You're the PCs, the folks that Stonetop looks to save them when danger looms. If you don't act like a hero, who will?

Avoid being overly cautious, or spending hours on careful, elaborate plans that cover every contingency. Plan a little, sure. Be clever. Play to your strengths and your weaknesses, and consider what your character, specifically, might do. But don't let the game grind to a halt. If you find yourself deliberating for more than a few minutes, stop. Make a choice. Act.

Play to find out what happens.

Embrace difficulty, setback, and failure

Not everything is going to go your way. Part of the GM's job is to present you with adversity and threaten the things you care about. Those challenges are meaningless unless the stakes are real, unless there's a chance you'll lose. Difficulty, setback, and failure are all key parts of **playing to find out what happens**.

Difficulty, setback, and failure are also an opportunity to **portray a compelling character**. Show us how you deal with adversity, how you rise to the challenge. Show us how loss affects you. Show us how you keep going anyway.

It's not that heroes don't fall down. It's that they get back up.

Playing the Game

Participate in worldbuilding

The GM is responsible for the world at large. But as you create your character, your playbook will prompt you to define things about the world: about the god you serve, about the troubles you've seen, about the NPCs who live in Stonetop. Choose options and make up details that you find interesting and compelling.

As you introduce your character, the GM will ask you questions. Lots of questions. Some of these will be about your PC specifically ("Do you know how to read?") but others will invite you to add details to the world ("Who, if anyone, did this job before you?"). Once play begins, the GM will continue to **ask questions and build on the answers**. They'll ask your character questions that help shape the world, questions like:

- ⊙ "Rhianna, who taught you how to hunt and track?"
- ⊙ "Blodwen, you live with your mother, right? Any siblings? What's the place look like inside?"
- ⊙ "Vahid, you've met Brennan before, what's his most distinctive feature?"
- ⊙ "Caradoc, what have you heard about the Quiet Twins and how they came to haunt the Stream?"
- ⊙ "Vahid, what have you noticed that all the missing children have in common?"
- ⊙ "What's the most striking detail about the Flats in early spring?"
- ⊙ "Caradoc, when you got back to Stonetop, whose reaction surprised you the most?"

Answer with enthusiasm, with color and life! Think about what you know about your character, what you know about the assumed setting, what other players have already established. Steal cool ideas from books or comics, from shows or movies, from other games, from real life. Add details that you want to see in the game, that you're excited about! Give answers that you think are cool and interesting, and you'll automatically be **engaging with the fictional world**.

With that said: don't overthink it. The best answer is often the obvious answer, the first thing that comes to mind. The first thing to come to your mind is often a surprise to the GM and other players, something they'd never have thought of, and thus you're helping them **play to find out what happens**.

If you find these sorts of questions off-putting or even stressful, consider why that is. Talk to your GM about it. If you don't like being put on the spot, the GM can ask you a question and then move the spotlight, giving you time to think. If you feel like you're being asked to do the GM's job (author the world) and that takes away from your fun, the GM can ask you fewer questions that involve worldbuilding and more questions about your PC's current thoughts and feelings.

But also, it could be that you're just not used to it. Many roleplaying games have a very strict line between the player's job and the GM's job, and *Stonetop* intentionally blurs that line. If worldbuilding isn't something you're used to doing, give it a try. Stretch yourself! The more you participate in worldbuilding, the easier it becomes.

Build on what others have said

Let yourself be inspired by your fellow players. Take elements that they introduce and use them yourself. Build on them, riff on them, tweak them.

Character creation is the most obvious time to build on what others have said. The Fox tells a tall tale about how she and her sister met a creepy old man in the woods? On your turn, re-use one of those elements! If you're the Ranger, maybe what you're worried about is that same creepy old man, spotted near the Ruined Tower. If you're the Would-be Hero, maybe the Fox's sister is the NPC whose heart you hope to win.

During play, when the GM asks questions, continue to build on each other's answers. Let your own ideas grow from what's already established. Don't make up something new when you can reuse and reincorporate. **Engage with the fictional world**, even as you create it!

Give others a chance to shine

Don't hog the spotlight. Be aware of how much you talk, relative to the other players. If you've been talking a lot, suggest a spotlight change. If a quiet player is talking, don't interrupt unless it's timely and valuable—and even then, raise your hand or wait for a natural pause.

Be proactive, too. Set others up for greatness! Has the Fox been flirting with one of your followers? Arrange for them to have a scene together, alone. Has the Blessed's player been quiet this session? Ask their PC to join yours on an errand, then strike up a conversation about something they care about.

This principle isn't about pursuing your agenda—it's about helping the other players to pursue *theirs*, to **portray compelling characters** and **engage with the fictional world**. But when you give each other a chance to shine, the results are often surprising, which means you're all **playing to find out what happens**.

Participate in the conversation

You play this game by talking to each other. The game is the conversation. Be an active, engaged part of that conversation. Otherwise, why are you here?

Pay attention, even when your PC isn't involved. Try to avoid distractions, in whatever way works for you (maybe take notes, or doodle, or knit, or whatever).

Ask questions. Ask for clarification, for more detail. Be curious! Ask players about their characters, about their actions, thoughts, and feelings.

Offer suggestions. If there's a pause in the conversation and you've got a good idea, offer it up.

Get excited! Ooh and ahh at the awesome stuff the other players say and do. Laugh at each other's jokes. Groan at each other's puns. Cheer when a clutch roll goes your way. Curse the fates when a roll comes up short.

You're going to have off nights, sessions where you're distracted or your energy is low. That's fine. But do what you can to focus, to pay attention, to participate in the conversation and enjoy the company of your friends. Because ultimately, that's what you're here to do.

Other things to do

Take notes! NPC names and traits. Who's related to whom. Bits of history and lore. Places. Things. The events of each session. If you think it'll be helpful to reference later, write it down. Your future self will thank you.

Learn the rules. You don't have to be an expert, but learn the basics. Know that "roll +STR" means you roll 2d6 and add your STR. Familiarize yourself with the **basic moves** (page 70), especially their triggers. Understand how **outfitting, gear, and possessions** work (page 86).

Know your character. You're the one with the playbook in front of you. Know what your stats are (or where to find them). Know what your damage die is. Know your moves, what triggers them, and what they do. Double-check things, sure, and everyone makes mistakes. But you are responsible for your character. Don't expect the GM or other players to tell you what your PC is capable of.

Watch for moves triggering. It's everyone's job to call out when moves trigger, or to question it when someone invokes a move without its trigger being met. "This feels like you're enticing her... Persuade?" "Is this really Defy Danger? Like, what's at stake?"

Work the fiction. Describe your actions in such a way that you trigger the moves you want to use, and avoid triggering moves you don't want to make. Exploit details of the established fiction, or suggest new ones that you think might help.

Advocate for yourself and for each other. If you think the GM has misinterpreted a move, or missed a detail, or skipped someone who's been waiting, say something! If you think another player is being a butt, ask them to knock it off. If you want to see something in the game, make that known. If someone else seems unhappy, ask them what's up. Communication is key!

Mind the vibe. Everyone is responsible for creating the game's tone, mood, and themes. Pay attention to the vibes at the table. Build on them, riff on them, respect them. If you like how "hope" is becoming a theme, then look for ways to explore or reinforce it. If everyone's playing serious, mud-spattered, and gritty, then don't name your brother "Fartwyn" or describe your PC as doing anime-style acrobatics.

Share the load. A lot of logistical tasks fall to the GM by default. But they don't have to! The GM has plenty to do just running the game, so do what you can to help. Divvy up responsibilities for:

- ⊙ Scheduling, hosting, ordering food
- ⊙ Printing materials
- ⊙ Taking notes
- ⊙ Updating the steading playbook
- ⊙ Recapping sessions
- ⊙ Explaining rules
- ⊙ Wrangling players between sessions ("Hey everyone, did you level up?")
- ⊙ Watching the clock, calling for breaks, nudging things along
- ⊙ Watching for discomfort, calling time out, checking in with others

Even if you don't take formal responsibility for these things, you can step in and help out as needed.

Ask questions! When you're unsure about some detail, ask for clarification. When you don't know what to do or how to answer a question, ask for advice.

Respect boundaries and wishes. Before you start play, you'll talk about the content that you and your fellow players want to exclude from the game, or veil and handle "off screen," or handle in particular ways. "No sexual violence," or, "Let's veil harm to animals," or, "Spiders are fine, but don't talk about how their legs move." Once play begins, you or other players can adjust these guidelines.

Respect these boundaries. If "torture" is excluded content, then *don't have your PC torture anyone*. It doesn't matter if "that's what my character would do." The boundaries and feelings of your fellow human beings are more important than your vision for your character, more important than your player agenda and principles. You and your friends are more important than the game.

When in doubt...

If the GM asks, "What do you do?" and you're unsure, do the following:

- ⊙ Visualize the situation
- ⊙ Ask the GM for clarification
- ⊙ Ask yourself, "What do I want? What's my goal?"
- ⊙ Consider your strengths and weaknesses
- ⊙ Look to others for advice
- ⊙ Go with the obvious choice, the interesting choice, the meaningful choice, not necessarily the "right" choice (and remember, you get XP on a 6-)!

What not to do

Don't roll until there's agreement. If you say "Ooh, I bet I Know Things about Fae" don't just pick up the dice and roll +INT. Wait for the GM and the rest of the group to acknowledge that, yeah, you're triggering a move, this move. If you roll for a move before the others agree that you've triggered it, then it doesn't count. Pick your dice back up.

Don't cheat. If you fudge your dice rolls to get the outcome you want, or you "forget" a rule or some detail established earlier, then you're not really **playing to find out what happens**. Roll your dice in the open, respect the established fiction, and play by the rules. You'll have more fun, and you won't be a cheater.

Don't keep secrets from other players. It's fine for your character to keep secrets from the other PCs. Heck, that's great! But the other players should be in on it, able to enjoy the dramatic irony.

Don't expect fights to be fair. Just because the GM puts a monster in front of you doesn't mean they think you can defeat it. Fights will not be "balanced" to your PCs. And even a fight with an "easy" foe can go sideways if the dice are against you. Judge your chances carefully, avoid fights that you can't handle, and be willing to flee if things go south.

Don't overthink it. Don't waste your time deliberating every decision, or making elaborate plans to cover every contingency, or thinking of the perfect answer to the GM's question. **Be bold, take risks, and embrace difficulty, setback, and failure.**

Your character

Every PC in *Stonetop* has a playbook. A playbook is a template, a set of choices and options that point towards a specific character archetype while still leaving room to make the character unique.

There are nine standard **playbooks**, which you can find starting on page 103. In play, though, you'll use either a printed copy of your playbook or an electronic version thereof. You can download these playbooks (and other materials) from www.lampblackandbrimstone.com.

To create your character, you'll choose a playbook and fill it out. Each playbook includes choices for your PC's...

- ⊗ Background
- ⊗ Instinct
- ⊗ Appearance
- ⊗ Place of origin and name
- ⊗ Stats
- ⊗ Playbook moves
- ⊗ Special possessions

Each playbook also includes:

- ⊗ A place to record debilities
- ⊗ Your damage die
- ⊗ Boxes in which to record your hit points (HP), armor, experience (XP), and current level
- ⊗ A set of prompts and questions that help you define part of the world
- ⊗ A procedure for introducing your PC to the rest of the group.

Background

Each playbook includes a choice of three backgrounds. Your choice tells us how your PC came to be the exceptional person that they are. It also helps define their backstory, and their role in the village of Stonetop.

Each background comes with one or more benefits: a unique move, a bonus playbook move, a special possession, etc.

Instinct

Your instinct describes how your PC tends to behave, for better or for worse. If you demonstrate your instinct in play, or struggle against it, you get to mark XP at the **end of the session** (page 232).

For your first PC, choose one of the instincts listed in your playbook. If you have played before, and none of the listed instincts feels right, feel free to pick an instinct from another playbook or make up a new one.

Your instinct can change during play. You'll be prompted to consider doing so each time you **Level Up** (page 81), but you can change your instinct any time it feels right to do so. Pick something else (from your playbook or another), or make up a new one. Just be sure to let the GM and the other players know.

Appearance

Each playbook prompts you to pick from a number of options for your character's appearance, or to make something else up. This is purely meant to help you visualize and flesh out your PC; it doesn't have any specific mechanical effect. Use your choices as a starting point, and feel free to add or change these details in play.

Place of origin and name

Stonetop is home (or close enough) to every PC, but you can decide where your character or your character's family came from originally. If you're not sure what to pick, pick Stonetop.

Each playbook presents a different set of possible origins. For your first PC, pick one of the origins listed—they're the most obvious and appropriate for that playbook. If you're already familiar with the world of *Stonetop* and have a clear idea, it's fine to pick a different origin.

Each origin provides a list of names to pick from. You don't have to pick one of the suggested names, but the lists are meant to give the world a cohesive feel. If you want something different, the **steading playbook** (page 154) includes additional names from each locale. Or you can search online for similar names.

Creating your character

At the start of a new game, make characters together, during the first session. It's cool to show up with a concept or some ideas in mind, but hold those ideas lightly. Be willing to discard or change them in response to the other players' ideas and interests.

Start by picking your playbook. Refer to the Setting Overview handout for a quick description of each playbook and its relative complexity. If you're unsure, look at the front page of each playbook to get a sense of what it's about. **No doubling up; each player should pick a different playbook.**

Work through your playbook from front to back, making choices as instructed. If your playbook mentions an insert or arcana, ask the GM for those. Stop when you get to "Introductions" and wait for the others.

If you're familiar with *Stonetop*, it's okay to suggest alternatives for your background, place of origin, special possessions, or even playbook moves. The GM and the rest of the group must all approve.

If you're joining an ongoing game, have the GM or another player brief you on the established details, and then make your PC before your first session. **If your PC retires or dies**, make a new PC between sessions. Either way, pick a background that could reflect a new arrival in the village or an NPC stepping up to PC status. Then work with the GM on the best way to introduce your new PC to the game.

Playing the Game

Stats

Each PC has six stats. When you trigger a move, and that move involves a roll, the move will tell you which stat to add.

Each stat has a three-letter abbreviation. The moves and game text refer almost exclusively to the abbreviation, just for the sake of space and brevity.

The six stats are:

- ⊙ **Strength (STR):** your physical power and your ability to use it. Roll +STR to Clash, or to Defy Danger with raw might or power.
- ⊙ **Dexterity (DEX):** your grace and fine motor control. Roll +DEX to Let Fly, or to Defy Danger with speed, agility, finesse.
- ⊙ **Intelligence (INT):** your memory, learning, and quick thinking. Roll +INT to Know Things, or to Defy Danger via expertise or with a clever plan.
- ⊙ **Wisdom (WIS):** your intuition, self-control, and awareness. Roll +WIS to Seek Insight, or when you rely on your willpower or senses to Defy Danger.
- ⊙ **Constitution (CON):** your stamina, grit, determination, and endurance. Roll +CON to Defend, or to Defy Danger by holding steady or enduring hardship.
- ⊙ **Charisma (CHA):** your ability to charm and connect with others, and to get a read on what others want. Roll +CHA to Persuade, or to Defy Danger socially.

Most playbooks will have you distribute the following to your stats: +2, +1, +1, +0, +0, and -1. Assign them as you wish, but you'll probably be happiest if you put the positive numbers in the stats you expect to use often. (Note: The Would-be Hero starts with worse stats than other playbooks, but offsets this through their Potential for Greatness move.)

You can increase your stats by taking the **Improved Stat** or **Superior Stat** playbook moves (see pages 106 and 107).

Debilities

During play, a move or the GM might tell you to “mark a debility.” There are three debilities:

- ⊙ **Weakened:** fatigued, tired, sluggish, shaky. Take disadvantage when rolling +STR or +DEX.
- ⊙ **Dazed:** out of it, befuddled, not thinking clearly. Take disadvantage when rolling +INT or +WIS.
- ⊙ **Miserable:** greatly distressed, angry, unwell, in pain. Take disadvantage when rolling +CON or +CHA.

There's a space on your playbook to mark each debility, just below the stats.

Debilities both reflect the fiction and dictate it. If something happens that results in you being fatigued, tired, and shaky, you'll mark *weakened* to reflect that. If you mark *weakened* because a move tells you to, then that means you become fatigued, tired, and shaky.

Debilities last until a move like **Recover** (page 328) or **Make Camp** (page 334) tells you to clear them, or until the GM tells you to.

Damage

Your playbook lists a die for damage. When you have the chance to hurt a foe, roll this die to see how much damage you deal.

Your damage die is independent of your weapon. If you're the Heavy, you deal 1d10 damage; if you're the Lightbearer, you deal 1d4. It doesn't matter whether you wield a dagger or a maul, or you're choking them with your bare hands. Your damage die reflects how dangerous you are. Your weapon is just a tool. (Some weapons of war deal "+1 damage," but they're the exception.)

Some moves override your damage die. A Lightbearer using Purifying Flames deals 1d10 damage, but only when they wield a holy light against a creature of darkness.

(And, no, you don't add STR or DEX to your damage rolls.)

Hit points (HP)

Your hit points (HP) represent how much fight you've got left in you. Start play with your current HP equal to your max HP, as noted in your playbook.

You lose HP when you take damage—when you are injured, hurt, roughed up, knocked around, etc. If you run out of HP, you're out of the action and might be dying.

You regain HP via moves like **Recover** (page 328) or **Make Camp** (page 334), but your current HP can never go higher than your max.

(No, you don't get more HP each level, nor do you add your CON to your HP.)

Armor

Your armor reduces the damage you take. For example, if you take 3 damage but have 1 armor, you only lose 2 HP.

Your armor is based on the gear you have equipped. Equipment that says "*n* armor" (like "1 armor" or "2 armor") doesn't stack; use the higher number. Equipment that says "+1 armor" *does* stack with other armor.

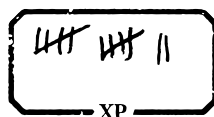
Armor is 0 by default. 0 or 1 armor is typical. 2 armor is tough. 3 armor is as good as you can get at the start of play.

XP

Short for "experience points." You start with no XP. You mark XP...

- ... **when you roll for a move and get a 6-** (unless the move says otherwise);
- ... **as part of the End of Session move** (page 232); and
- ... **when another move says so.**

"Mark XP" means that you make a tick mark in the XP box on your playbook, increasing your total XP by 1. Like so:



Once you've marked enough XP, you can spend it to either **Burn Brightly** (page 231) or **Level Up** (page 81).

Playing the Game

Level

Your level reflects how much your PC has grown in competence and capability. You start at level 1. When you mark XP equal to 6 plus twice your current level, you can take some downtime and spend that XP to **Level Up** (page 81).

Each time you Level Up, you gain a new move from your playbook. At level 6, you gain access to your playbook's most potent moves. There is no maximum level, but each level requires 2 more XP to reach than the last.

If you're making a new character to join an ongoing game, you still start at level 1, no matter what level the other PCs are at. Don't worry about "power imbalance." A low-level PC doesn't have quite the range of options that a high-level one has, but they're still plenty effective.

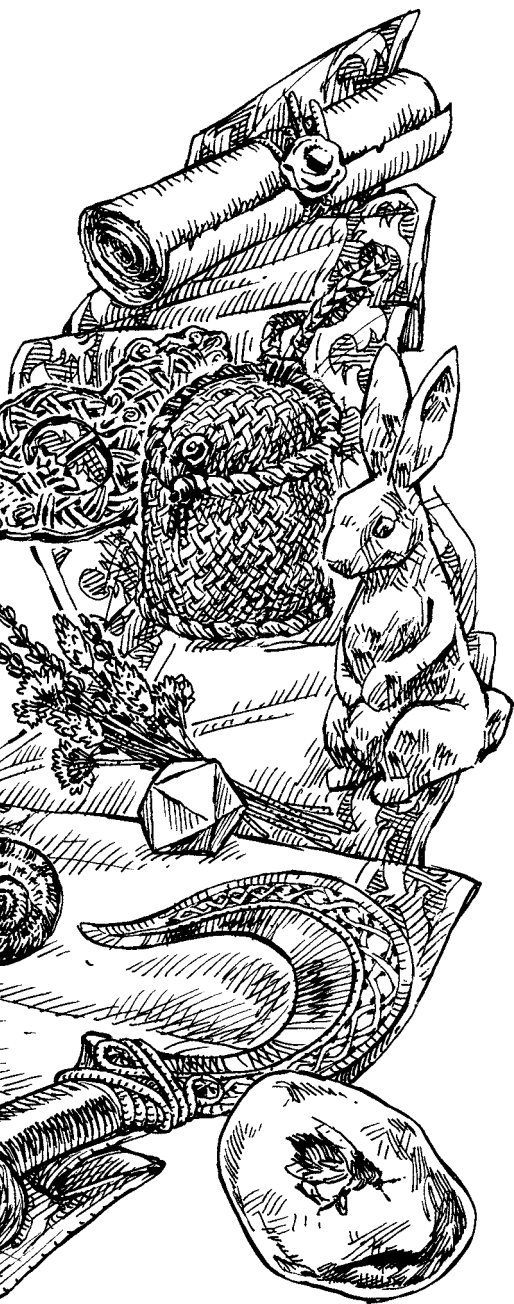
Special possessions

Your special possessions are the unique or interesting things that you own or have access to.

In addition to your special possessions, you have access to common weapons, armor, and gear listed on the **Inventory insert** (page 142). See the section on **Gear and possessions** (page 86) for more info.

Consider how your special possessions reflect your PC's role in the village. You have the tannery (or access to it)? Cool, are you the village tanner, then? Their apprentice? The tanner's close kin? You have a distillery, huh? Do you help run the public house? Or make whisky at home for you and yours? Are you the main distiller, or one of many? Do you have any rivals? That sort of thing.





Moves

Each playbook has a selection of moves. You'll start play with 3 or 4 of them; your playbook tells you which, or which to choose from. Each time you **Level Up** (page 81), you get a new move from your playbook.

Some playbook moves lack **triggers** (page 39); you simply gain their benefit when you take them. If you take the Improved Stat move, you permanently increase one of your stats. If you take a move that lets you always ask something, you can just do that now!

If a move says "(Requires __)," then you must meet that requirement in order to take the move. The requirement might be a level, another move, or the specific playbook (meaning that other playbooks can never take this move, even when they take a move that lets them pick from another playbook, see below.)

If a move *replaces* a different move, then it requires the one it replaces. When you take such a move, you lose the original move and any benefits that it conferred.

Many playbooks include a move that lets you pick from another playbook. Most of these moves limit which playbooks you can pick from.

If you really want to take a specific move from another playbook, but you don't have an option to do so, then pitch your idea to the GM and the other players. If everyone agrees, okay. But there are reasons why the playbooks have access to the moves they do. Magic-oriented playbooks have less flexibility when picking from other playbooks, and their moves aren't as freely available to others.

Playing the Game

World building

On the back of each playbook, in the left column, you'll find a series of questions and prompts that will help you define the world and your character's place in it. Fill these out on your own, to the best of your ability.

At the start of a new game, your answers to these prompts and questions can have a big impact on what Stonetop and the wider world look like for your group. If you're joining an ongoing game or creating a replacement PC, you should make choices that jive with what's been established for that game.

Expect the GM to ask questions about this stuff. When and where did this happen? Who else was involved? How'd you end up there in the first place? Etc. It's good to think a little about this in advance, but as always, hold your ideas lightly. You might want to change them a bit once you hear what the other players have to say.

Introductions

Each playbook ends with a procedure for introducing your character to the group. This is to meant to happen during the first session, after you all choose and fill out your playbooks. The GM will walk the group through it, together, asking lots of questions. Pay attention to the other players, ask questions yourself, and riff on the details they provide.

The introductions procedure assumes that your character is already established in the village. If you're making a new character to add to an ongoing game, work with the GM and other players to determine the best way to introduce your new PC.



If your new PC was previously an NPC who is “stepping up” to PC status, then maybe do a pared-down version of this procedure between sessions (via email, group chat, etc.) or at the start of the next one. Some of the answers might be obvious, but some might be surprises.



If your new PC is a recent arrival in Stone-top, you might skip this procedure entirely and actually play out their arrival in town. Or the group might skip ahead in time, saying that your new PC arrived a couple months ago and has gotten settled in, and then you can walk through the Introductions normally at the start of a session.

Inserts

Every playbook comes with an insert, a half-page sheet that you can slip inside your folded playbook. Copies of these are provided for reference in this book, starting on page 141.

Every playbook gets an insert for tracking your current **inventory** (page 142), the other side of which is used to track **followers** (page 147) or playbook-specific information, such as the Lightbearer's **invocations** (page 146) or the Marshal's **crew** (page 144).

The Blessed and Ranger might have special inserts, if you take a particular background or move. The Seeker gets an additional insert for their **major arcanum** (see *Book II*, starting on page 540). So does the Heavy, but only if you pick the **Storm-marked** background (page 113).

You can gain new inserts during play. If you die and you refuse to step through the Last Door, then you gain the **Ghost**, **Revenant**, or **Thrall** inserts (pages 148, 150, and 152). Your GM might also give you a custom-made insert to represent a unique set of abilities that your character acquires during play (see **Writing Moves & Love Letters**, page 549).

Arcana

Arcana are magical items, places, or lore that can provide power—but only if you spend the time and effort to fully unlock their mysteries. The Seeker starts with a collection of arcana, and anyone can acquire them in play.

Every arcanum is different. Some are spells or abilities that you can learn by studying some scrap of lore, and any number of people could learn the same spell. Some imbue you with magical power. Other arcana are magical objects that you can learn to wield. Still others are magical places that you must return to in order to use their power.

When questions arise about an arcanum (like how it works, what's involved with using it, what it can/can't do, etc.), talk it out with the GM and the other players. Consider the details described or implied or already established in play, and extrapolate an answer together.

Minor arcana

Each minor arcanum is represented by a little card. You can see an example below.

The front side, as seen in the example below, shows what you can tell about the arcanum at a glance or with a little study. It also says what's required to unlock the arcanum's mysteries.

Unlocking a minor arcanum's mysteries often requires significant time, usually spent between expeditions. Don't be surprised if the GM asks you what chores or obligations go unmet as you pursue this magical power.

✧ MINOR ARCANUM ✧

An old scroll case

◇, *fragile*

A leather scroll case, cracked and age-worn. Inside is a tattered letter and a pair of small, bluish ingots. It's a letter, in an older Hillfolk dialect, from an apprentice to their master. It describes a mental exercise to draw latent power from aetherium.

You can learn **Laoj Davith's Galvanic Infusion** from the scroll, but...

- ☐ ... you must translate the letter.
- ☐ ... it'll take a few weeks of dedicated study.
- ☐ ... you'll use up one of the aetherium ingots (or another source of aetherium).
- ☐ ... you risk electrocuting yourself and/or using up the other ingot.

FRONT

1

When a requirement says that “you risk ____,” then you’ll be **Defying Danger** (page 210) unless you can come up with some way of eliminating that risk. Learning magic is rarely easy or safe.

Meet the requirements, and you unlock its mysteries. You gain whatever move and/or follower appears on the back of the card.

You can share a minor arcanum with another PC or even an NPC, as long as it makes sense to do so. Work with the GM to identify how the requirements change for them unlocking the arcanum’s mysteries.

For example, if you mastered Laoj Davith’s Galvanic Infusion (using up both of the aetherium ingots in the process) and gave the old scroll case to another PC, then...

- ... they’d need to acquire a couple pieces of aetherium before trying to unlock its mysteries themselves;
- ... you might **Aid** (page 212) them by sharing your notes and coaching them, granting advantage when they Defy Danger to avoid the risk; and/or...
- ... they might need only a few days of dedicated study, rather than a few weeks, as long as you show them the ropes.

If they complete all the requirements, then they can cast Laoj Davith’s Galvanic Infusion, too!

Remember, though, that every arcanum is different. A magic spear that you bind to yourself with blood and fire isn’t as easily shared as a spell written on a scroll.

MINOR ARCANUM

Laoj Davith’s Galvanic Infusion

When you *touch a piece of aetherium and draw its power into yourself*, roll +CON: **on a 7+**, you absorb the power and gain 1d8 HP (even if this puts you above your max HP); **but on a 7-9**, the aetherium is drained and crumbles into a chalky mass of verdigris.

The spell lasts until you dismiss it or until you roll a 6- on any move. While it lasts, you need not sleep and remain highly alert and focused—gain advantage on any rolls with WIS.

If you remain awake for more than a few days, your body grows ever more exhausted and you risk hallucination, paranoia, and addiction.

When *the spell ends*, you lose 1d8 HP.

BACK

1

Playing the Game

Major arcana

Each major arcanum is represented by a half-page insert. They are generally more potent than minor arcana, with the potential to provide multiple moves and powers. But they are also much more dangerous, and using their powers comes at the risk of ever-greater consequences.

Opposite and on the page following is “Noruba’s Ice Sphere,” an example of a major arcanum insert, included here for reference.

Front side

The front side of each major arcanum shows what you can tell about it at first glance or with a bit of study.

Most major arcana provide a move or some other mechanical benefit, even before you unlock their mysteries.

The front of a major arcanum also says how to unlock its mysteries. This might involve meeting requirements (as with minor arcana) or using the arcanum’s move(s) and getting certain results. Each major arcanum works differently.

Mysteries

The back of each major arcanum shows its mysteries: additional moves or options that the arcanum can provide.

When you unlock a major arcanum’s mysteries, you get access to one or more of these moves or options (the front side will tell you which). You might be able to gain more, as detailed on the major arcanum itself.

Consequences

The back of each major arcanum also lists its potential consequences. You mark a consequence when a move tells you to, or when you roll a 6- on a move and the GM tells you to mark one.

You get to pick which consequence you mark. Whatever that consequence says, it happens. Don’t mark a “nested” or indented consequence unless you’ve already marked the consequence under which it is nested; beyond that restriction, you can mark them in any order. You’ll probably want to start with the ones near the top, though.

Consequences can be marked only once (or in a few cases, once per check box). There’s no standard way to uncheck a consequence; they’re a limited resource. Each time you mark a consequence, you must mark an empty check box.

What happens if you mark all the consequences? That depends on the arcanum. Some include a consequence that has the object break or vanish, which makes the question moot. Others require you to mark a consequence in order to use one or more moves; and if you can’t mark a consequence, you can’t use such a move. But if an arcanum says to mark a consequence as a result of one of its moves, and you’ve already marked them all, then you and your group have to decide what happens. Maybe the item is safer to use now, since you can’t suffer any more consequences. Or maybe the GM gets to make something up, on par with the consequences that we’ve already seen in play. Decide together, case by case.



Noruba's Ice Sphere

◇, magical, awkward

A perfect sphere of dark ice, the size of a fist, never melting, hard as stone, and set like a gaudy gem at the end of a finely wrought torc. Or not a torc, perhaps, but maybe a ring that once sat upon some giant's finger?

Staring into the icy sphere brings a sense of calm, serenity, and detachment. Indeed, a lesser mind might find itself staring into its depths for hours on end.

When you *peer into the Ice Sphere*, your mind is cleared of strong emotions.

When you *gaze deeply into the Ice Sphere and ponder a situation, puzzle, or mystery*, ask the GM one of the questions below. The GM will answer honestly.

- ⊗ Who benefits (or would benefit) from ___?
- ⊗ What about ___ isn't what it seems to be?
- ⊗ How could I learn more about ___?
- ⊗ What's the most likely outcome if ___?
- ⊗ What am I overlooking?

After the GM answers, roll +INT: **on a 10+**, hold 2 Acumen; **on a 7-9**, hold 1. ○○
While acting on the GM's answer, you can spend Acumen 1-for-1 to:

- ⊗ Ask another question from the list above, and get an honest answer
- ⊗ Treat a 6- that you rolled as a 7-9, or a 7-9 as a 10+

On a 6-, your connection to your body weakens—mark a debility and mark 1 circle. The debility lasts until you spend a few days living wholly in your body and averting your gaze from the Ice Sphere.

When you *make the last mark*, you unlock the mysteries of the Ice Sphere and can use Mindwalking (see reverse).

Mysteries of Noruba's Ice Sphere

Moves

☐ MINDWALKING ○○○○

When you *use the Ice Sphere as a psychic anchor*, your consciousness leaves your body and walks the world as a spirit, invisible and insubstantial. Roll +INT: **on a 10+**, hold 3 Power; **on a 7-9**, hold 2 Power; **on a 6-**, hold 2 Power and mark a Consequence. While mindwalking, you may spend your Power, 1-for-1 to:

- ⊗ Manifest as a ghostly voice and/or presence
- ⊗ Manipulate a small (weight 0), unattended object
- ⊗ Return instantly to the Ice Sphere from any distance

For every 2 Consequences you mark, gain one of the following moves:

☐ A MIGHTY WILL

When you *mindwalk*, hold +1 Power.

☐ FARWALKER

When you *mindwalk*, you may spend 1 Power to instantly send your mind to any place you have ever visited, physically or mentally.

☐ TELEPATHY

When you *mindwalk*, you may spend 1 Power to become able to communicate mentally with someone nearby, as long as you remain in their presence. They can choose whether to respond, and can attempt to ignore you, but cannot shut you out completely without magic of their own.

☐ TULPA

When you *mindwalk*, you may spend 1 Power to animate a mass of loose material (gravel, snow, leaves, etc.) into a body no larger than your own. When you would roll STR, DEX, or CON in this form, use INT instead. This form has 10 HP. When reduced to 0 HP, it dissipates and you return to your physical body.

Consequences

- ☐ Your physical body withers and fades—permanently mark the *weakened* debility
- ☐ Your emotions dull. You can no longer be affected by fear, hate, or other powerful emotions (for good or ill).
- ☐ Replace your instinct with “Detachment: To distance yourself from human connections and emotions.”
- ☐ Your skin tinges bluish; your body becomes cold to the touch. You are unaffected by even the bitterest cold, but find heat and warmth unbearable.
 - ☐ When you take damage from fire, roll twice and take the higher result.
- ☐ You draw the attention of some powerful, hungry entity of the spirit world. It has your scent. Should you destroy or bind it, erase this mark.
- ☐ When you roll 6- at Death's Door, you have no choice: gain the Ghost insert (with the Ice Sphere as your tether).

Sharing major arcana

You can share a major arcanum with another PC or even an NPC, as long as it makes sense to do so. In general:

- ⊙ Each character must unlock the mysteries of the major arcanum on their own.
- ⊙ Each character tracks their own consequences separately, which means that each of you can suffer the same consequence(s)

With that said, each major arcanum is different and there will be exceptions. Talk it over with the GM and the other players to determine what makes sense.

If you and another PC share a major arcanum over any extended period, you should probably each have your own copy of the insert to track your own progress, mysteries, and consequences. Just be clear on who is actually wielding the arcanum at any given time.



Followers

A follower is a non-player character (NPC) who takes orders from you and generally follows your lead.

Followers are NPCs, meaning the GM is ultimately responsible for what they do and say, but...

- ... they'll generally do as you say;
- ... they can accumulate **Loyalty** (see below), which makes them easier to lead and manage; and
- ... when you direct them to act, they can trigger moves on your behalf.

Here's how you can get followers:

- ⊙ The Marshal starts with a crew of followers, automatically. Track them on your Crew insert.
- ⊙ The Blessed starts with followers if you take the Initiate background. Track them on the Initiates of Danu insert.
- ⊙ The Ranger starts with a follower if you take the Beast-bonded background or the Animal Companion move. Track them on the Animal Companion insert.
- ⊙ You might pick one or more dogs as a Special Possession, who act as followers. Track them on the back of the standard Inventory insert.
- ⊙ The Seeker might start with an unlocked minor arcanum that acts as a follower. If so, track it on the arcanum card itself.
- ⊙ Any PC can gain followers over the course of play.

Followers have the following stats:

- ⊙ **Tags** (like *warrior*, *stubborn*, or *tall*) that describe the follower; when you **Order Followers** (page 462), their tags affect what you roll.
- ⊙ **Damage**, **hit points**, and **armor** (page 53), which work the same for followers as they do for PCs.
- ⊙ An **instinct**, which describes how they tend to cause trouble for you.
- ⊙ **GM moves**, written as things that they can/will do (like “► Sniff out trouble on the wind”); not every follower has these.
- ⊙ A **cost**, which describes what keeps them following your lead

When you pay a follower's cost, they hold Loyalty towards you. You can then spend that Loyalty to have them overcome their fear, resist their instinct or tags, or do something they don't want to do (within reason). See **Strengthen Your Bond** (page 464) for details.

A follower with the *group* tag represents multiple individuals who share stats and often act as one. Members of a group have the same tags, max HP, armor, damage, instinct, GM moves, and cost. They share a pool of Loyalty but each has their own current HP.

You can direct a *group* follower to act as a unit, or give orders to individual members. When an individual member stands out, you or the GM might assign a tag or two just for them. For example, if you're the Marshal, everyone in your crew might have the *archer*, *observant*, *stealthy*, and *respected* tags, but your lieutenant Eira might also be *cynical*.



Your home

Every PC lives in or near the village of Stonetop; it's the focal point of play.

The village itself has its own playbook, a living document that changes as you play. Stonetop's **steading playbook** is reproduced starting on page 154.

The steading playbook includes:

- ⊙ The steading's size, stats, and current debilities
- ⊙ Its current Surplus
- ⊙ Its resources, fortifications, etc.
- ⊙ The places of interest in the village
- ⊙ Improvements that you're working on, and those that you've completed
- ⊙ The village's communal assets
- ⊙ A place to record important NPCs
- ⊙ Maps of the vicinity and the region

Size

Size reflects the scale of the steading's infrastructure, its baseline population. The possible values for Size are:

- ⊙ *hamlet* (<50 people)
- ⊙ *village* (150-350 people)
- ⊙ *town* (500-1500 people)
- ⊙ *city* (2500+ people)

Size affects how much **Surplus** (page 67) is consumed each winter. If the steading becomes a *town*, you'll have advantage to **Muster** (page 82), **Pull Together** (page 83), and **Trade & Barter** (page 83). If it becomes a *hamlet*, you'll have disadvantage on those moves.

Stonetop starts as a *village*, home to about 300 souls. If things go poorly, it could shrink and become a *hamlet*. If you complete enough **steading improvements** (page 68), it can become a *town*.

Playing the Game

Content

At the beginning of your first session, you and the rest of the group will have a discussion about content. In particular, you'll have a chance to establish:

- ⊙ **Excluded content**, that won't be part of the game at all (on-camera or off)
- ⊙ **Veiled content**, that can be part of the game (but only off-camera)
- ⊙ **Special requests** for how certain content gets handled (like, "Spiders are okay, but please don't describe their legs" or "Let's say that gender norms in Stonetop are super fluid and accepting").

Record these content guidelines on the second page of the steading playbook. Review the guidelines at the start of each session. Call "time out" any time you realize that these guidelines have been broken or ignored, or if you feel that you need to add to or modify these guidelines.

Steading stats

Stonetop has four stats, each of which ranges from -1 to +3. The four steading stats are:

- ⊙ **Fortunes**: morale, social cohesion, and just "how it's going." Roll +Fortunes when Seasons Change to see what happens in the coming months, or when you Requisition one of the village's assets.
- ⊙ **Population**: the number of able bodies in town, relative to its Size. Population is a double-edged sword; add it to rolls to Muster or Pull Together, but also add it to the amount of Surplus consumed each winter.
- ⊙ **Prosperity**: the quality and variety of services and household goods, tools and weapons, finery and little luxuries. Roll +Prosperity to Trade & Barter, and add it to the number of uses you get from supplies, the HP you regain when you Recover, and the piercing value of your iron weapons.
- ⊙ **Defenses**: the martial prowess and readiness of the steading; how well-trained and well-armed the inhabitants are. Roll +Defenses to Deploy.

Fortunes start at +1 and change frequently during play. The other three stats start at +0. Population changes in response to the **Seasons Change** (page 84) and **Meet with Disaster** (page 82) moves. Prosperity and Defenses increase if you complete certain **improvements** (page 68), and decrease if you lose key resources in play.

Debilities

During play, your steading can suffer debilities much like your PC can (page 52). There are three steading debilities:

- ⊙ ***Diminished***, by injury, sickness, doubt. Take disadvantage to **Deploy** (page 81), **Muster** (page 82), or **Pull Together** (page 83).
- ⊙ ***Lacking***, due to shortages, hoarding, distrust. Treat Prosperity as if it's 1 lower than it is.
- ⊙ ***Malcontent***, from fear, anger, and/or despair. Fortunes reset to +0 each season, instead of +1 (page 84), and folks need Persuading more often than usual.

There's a space on the steading playbook to mark each debility.

Debilities both reflect the fiction and dictate it. If something happens that results in the village's capacity being reduced by injury, sickness, or doubt, you'll mark *diminished* to reflect that. If you mark *diminished* because a move tells you to, then that means injury, sickness, and/or doubt plague the steading.

Steading debilities last until a move like **Return Triumphant** (page 79) says to clear them, or until the GM tells you to.

Surplus

Surplus represents food in the granary and in household larders, livestock ready for slaughter, whisky that's ready to drink, fur that's ready to trade or be fashioned into garments. It's a resource that you accumulate, consume, and spend.

At the start of play, Stonetop holds 1 Surplus; there's no upper limit. The village generates Surplus each summer and autumn, and consumes Surplus each winter. You can gain more Surplus through trade, by going on an expedition to hunt big game, or as a good result when **Seasons Change** (page 84). You can spend Surplus to trade for other assets or to have folks **Pull Together** (page 83) on a project.

Resources & fortifications

Next to the steading's Prosperity, you'll see a list of resources (farming, hunting/ trapping, stone from the Old Wall, etc.).

Next to the steading's Defenses, you'll see a list of fortifications and other elements that help keep the village safe (the village militia, the Ringwall, etc.)

As you establish new resources, fortifications, or other defensive elements, you'll add them here. Should the village lose these resources temporarily, it will suffer debilities. Should it lose them permanently, its Prosperity and/or Defenses will go down.

Playing the Game

Places of interest

The Steading playbook includes a map of the village, noting key places like the Stone itself, the granary, the public house, and so forth.

As part of introducing your PCs, you'll add their homes to this map. You'll also add any additional places of interest, such as the Chronicle (if someone plays the Judge) and the homes of notable NPCs.

Steading improvements

The Steading playbook includes a number of potential **improvements** (page 156) that you can pursue. There are also spots for new improvements, which the GM might reveal to you in play.

Each Steading improvement has a list of requirements, which you can complete in whatever order makes sense. You don't have to go in order unless an improvement specifically says you do.

Once you meet all the requirements for an improvement, the Steading gains the listed benefit(s). Some improvements increase Steading stats (like Fortunes, Prosperity, or Defenses). Some provide new moves. Some do both.

Some improvements incur ongoing costs. For example, the Weapons of War improvement requires 1 Surplus every spring to maintain. If you fail to pay that cost, you lose the improvement. **Make a Plan** (page 81) with the GM if you want to get it back.

The GM can threaten or harm Steading improvements the same way they can threaten anything else you care about. If you don't do something to save it, it will be lost and you'll lose its benefits. Again, **Make a Plan** (page 81) if you want to get it back.



Assets

After the improvements, the steading playbook has a section for recording **assets** (page 161) that are owned by the residents of Stonetop in common: a pair of draft horses, a couple iron plows, a couple carts, a horse-drawn wagon, and anything else the village gains in play.

This section also includes boxes in which to record any silver or gold coins. These start blank, but should you acquire coins during play and turn them over to the village as a whole, you'd record them here. See page 93 for more on **coins**.

If you want to take any of these assets on an expedition, you must first **Requisition** them (page 77).



NPCs

Finally, the steading playbook has places to record notable non-player characters (NPCs). There's a section for **Residents of Stonetop** (page 162), and one for **Notable neighbors of Stonetop** (page 164).

Each time you establish a new NPC (during character introductions or in the course of play), give them a name and note their pronouns. Pick a name from the appropriate list in the steading playbook, or pick an unused name from the front of your playbook.

Note each NPC's occupation, and give each a notable, memorable trait. Pick one of the **NPC traits** (page 163) from the steading playbook, or make one up.

Also note any relationships that are important to understanding the NPC, like "Nolwen's sister" or "Urgben's mother (hates Trystan)."

Other ways to track NPCs

A game of *Stonetop* can easily involve dozens of NPCs, and space on the steading playbook is limited. Your group might opt to use a digital tool for tracking NPCs, such as:

- ⊙ A relationship map, to visually organize PCs, NPCs, and their relationships.
- ⊙ A matrix or spreadsheet, with a row for each PC or NPC, and columns for traits and relations.
- ⊙ A wiki or database, with an entry for each PC or NPC and links between them all to record relationships.

Playing the Game

The moves

The following moves are available to all PCs. They're organized based on the context in which they apply.

Remember, if a move calls for a roll and doesn't say what happens on a 6-, **mark XP** (page 53) **and prepare for the worst**.

Basic moves

These are the most commonly triggered moves, the ones that can come up in many different contexts.



AID

When you *help someone who has not yet rolled*, the GM picks 1:

- ⊙ They can accomplish more than they could alone
- ⊙ They gain advantage on their roll.

Either way, you are exposed to any risk, cost, or consequence associated with their roll.

For more information, see page 212.

CLASH

When you *fight in melee or close quarters*, roll +STR: **on a 10+**, your maneuver works as expected (deal your damage) and pick 1.

- ⊙ Avoid, prevent, or counter your enemy's attack
- ⊙ Strike hard and fast, for 1d6 extra damage, but suffer your enemy's attack

On a 7-9, your maneuver works, mostly (deal your damage) but you suffer your enemy's attack.

For more information, see page 214.



DEFEND

When you *take up a defensive stance* or *jump in to protect others*, roll +CON: **on a 10+**, hold 3 Readiness (or 4 if you bear a shield); **on a 7-9**, hold 1 Readiness (or 2 with a shield). You can spend Readiness 1-for-1 to:

- ⊙ Suffer an attack's damage/effects instead of your ward
- ⊙ Halve an attack's effect or damage
- ⊙ Draw all attention from your ward to yourself
- ⊙ Strike back at an attacker (deal your damage, with disadvantage)

When you *go on the offense, cease to focus on defense, or the threat passes*, lose any Readiness that you hold.

For more information, see page 216.

DEFY DANGER

When *danger looms, the stakes are high, and you do something chancy*, check if another move applies. If not, roll...

- ... +STR to power through or test your might
- ... +DEX to employ speed, agility, or finesse
- ... +CON to endure or hold steady
- ... +INT to apply expertise or enact a clever plan
- ... +WIS to exert willpower or rely on your senses
- ... +CHA to charm, bluff, impress, or fit in

On a 10+, you pull it off as well as one could hope; **on a 7-9**, you can do it, but the GM will present a lesser success, a cost, or a consequence (and maybe a choice between them, or a chance to back down).

For more information, see page 210.

Playing the Game

INTERFERE

When you try to foil another PC's action and neither of you back down, roll...

- ... +STR to power through or test your might
- ... +DEX to employ speed, agility, or finesse
- ... +CON to endure or hold steady
- ... +INT to apply expertise or enact a clever plan
- ... +WIS to exert willpower or rely on your senses
- ... +CHA to charm, bluff, impress, or fit in

On a 10+, they pick 1 from the list below; **on a 7-9**, they pick 1 from the list below but you are left off-balance, exposed, or otherwise vulnerable.

- ⊙ Do it anyway, but with disadvantage on their (next) roll
- ⊙ Relent, change course, or otherwise allow their move to be foiled

For more information, see page 218.

KNOWTHINGS

When you *consult your accumulated knowledge*, roll +INT: **on a 10+**, the GM will tell you something interesting and useful about the topic at hand; **on a 7-9**, the GM will tell you something interesting—it's on you to make it useful; **either way**, the GM might ask "how do you know this?"

For more information, see page 220.

LET FLY

When you *take an easy shot with a ranged weapon*, deal your damage. *If the shot is tricky or you're under pressure*, first roll +DEX: **on a 10+**, you have a clear shot, deal your damage; **on a 7-9**, pick 1:

- ⊙ Deal your damage, but deplete your ammo (mark the next status by your weapon; don't pick this if your weapon lacks such statuses)
- ⊙ Hold steady and wait for a clear shot; when the moment arrives (GM's call), deal your damage
- ⊙ Move to get a clear shot—exposing yourself to danger or giving up some advantage (GM says how)—then deal your damage
- ⊙ Rush the shot and deal your damage, leading to a cost or complication of the GM's choice

For more information, see page 222.

PERSUADE (vs. NPCs)

When you *press or entice an NPC*, say what you want them to do (or not do). If they *have reason to resist*, roll +CHA: **on a 10+**, they either do as you want or reveal the easiest way to convince them; **on a 7-9**, they reveal something you can do to convince them, though it'll likely be costly, tricky, or distasteful.

For more information, see page 224.

PERSUADE (vs. PCs)

When you *press or entice a PC and they resist*, ask their player: "Could I possibly get you to do this, yes or no?" If they say "no," let it drop.

If they say "yes," you can roll +CHA: **on a 10+**, they mark XP if they do what you want, and if they don't, they must say how you could convince them; **on a 7-9**, they mark XP if they do what you want (but can refuse or make a counter-offer if they like).

For more information, see page 226.

SEEK INSIGHT

When you *study a situation or person*, looking to the GM for insight, roll +WIS: **on a 10+**, ask the GM 3 questions from the list below; **on a 7-9**, ask 1; **either way**, take advantage on your next move to act on the answers.

- ⊗ What happened here recently?
- ⊗ What is about to happen?
- ⊗ What should I be on the lookout for?
- ⊗ What here is useful or valuable to me?
- ⊗ Who or what is really in control here?
- ⊗ What here is not what it appears to be?

For more information, see page 228.

Playing the Game

Special moves

These moves are always in play, but they either affect other moves or are triggered by very specific circumstances.

ADVANTAGE/DISADVANTAGE

When you *make a roll with advantage*, roll an extra die and discard the lowest result.

When you *make a roll with disadvantage*, roll an extra die and discard the highest result.

When you *make a roll with both advantage and disadvantage*, they cancel each other out.

If you *have advantage/disadvantage on a damage roll*, roll the main die twice and discard the lower/higher result. Then add any bonus dice that apply.

For more information, see page 230.

BURN BRIGHTLY

When you *have enough XP to Level Up* (6 + twice your current level), you may spend 2 XP after any roll to add +1 to that roll (maximum +1 per roll).

For more information, see page 231.

END OF SESSION

When a *session ends*, point out how you demonstrated or struggled with your instinct. If you can, mark XP.

Say how your relationship with or opinion of a PC, NPC, or group has changed. If you can, mark XP.

Answer these questions as a group. For each “yes,” everyone marks XP.

- ☞ Did we learn more about the world or its history?
- ☞ Did we defeat a threat to Stonetop or the region?
- ☞ Did we improve our standing with our neighbors?
- ☞ Did we make a lasting improvement to Stonetop, or tangible progress towards doing so?

Praise something about the session (in the fiction or around the table) that you enjoyed or appreciated.

Finally, offer up a wish for future sessions: more __, less __, a chance to __, handling __ in a different way, etc. Wishes can be about what happens in the fiction or around the table. The GM will take notes.

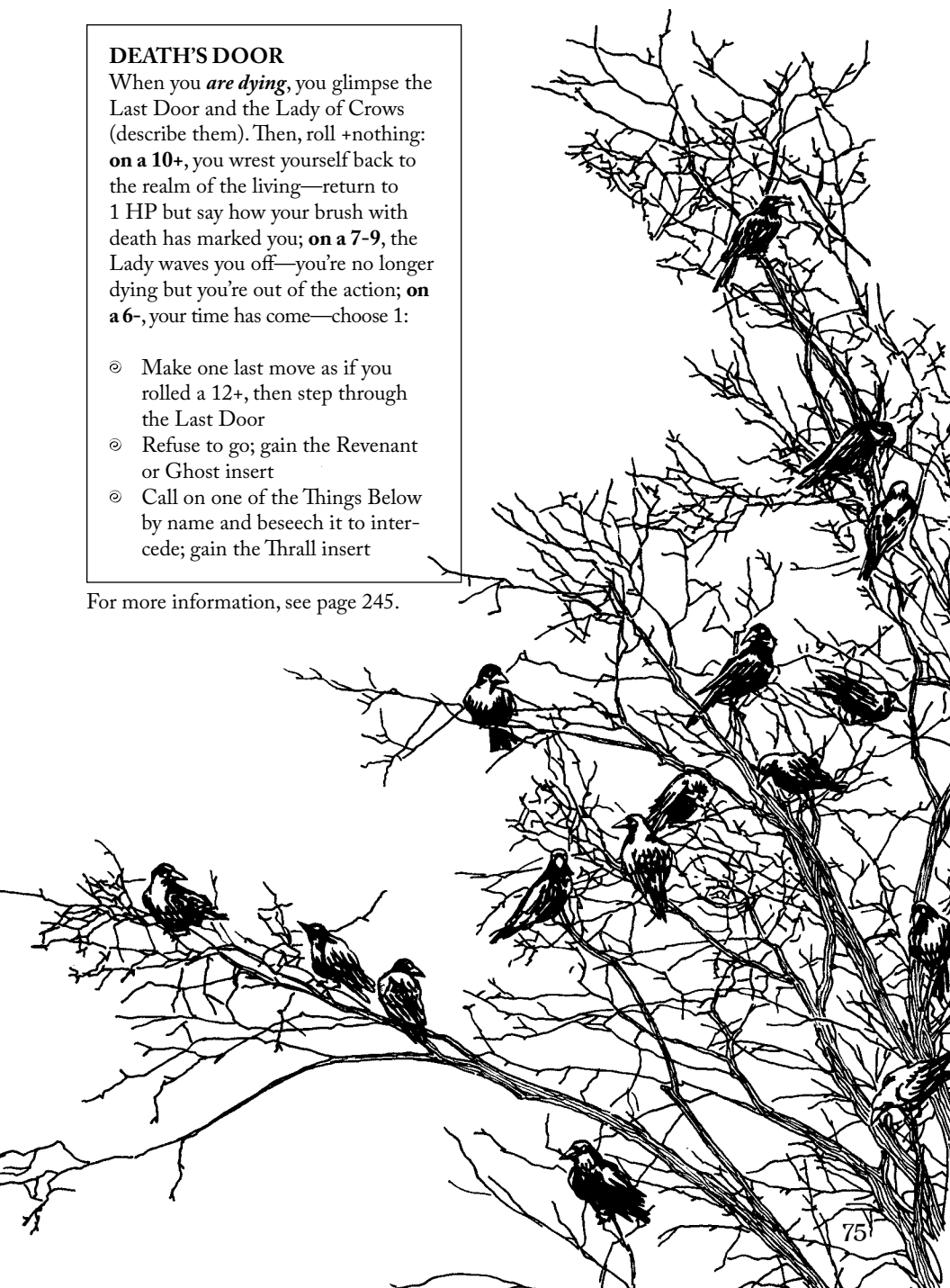
For more information, see page 232.

DEATH'S DOOR

When you *are dying*, you glimpse the Last Door and the Lady of Crows (describe them). Then, roll +nothing: **on a 10+**, you wrest yourself back to the realm of the living—return to 1 HP but say how your brush with death has marked you; **on a 7-9**, the Lady waves you off—you're no longer dying but you're out of the action; **on a 6-**, your time has come—choose 1:

- ⊙ Make one last move as if you rolled a 12+, then step through the Last Door
- ⊙ Refuse to go; gain the Revenant or Ghost insert
- ⊙ Call on one of the Things Below by name and beseech it to intercede; gain the Thrall insert

For more information, see page 245.



Playing the Game

Follower moves

These moves apply when you interact with your **followers** (page 64).

ORDER FOLLOWERS

When you *direct your follower to do something that would trigger a player move*, and they do it, they trigger the move. If the move involves rolling, you roll for them. Instead of rolling +STAT, roll and...

- ... if they have at least one appropriate tag or move, add +1, or +2 if they're also *exceptional*;
- ... if they have no relevant tag or move, add +0; and
- ... if any of their tags would get in the way, roll with disadvantage.

When a follower is without orders or they act on their own initiative, the GM says what they do and decides how it goes.

For more information, see page 462.

STRENGTHEN YOUR BOND

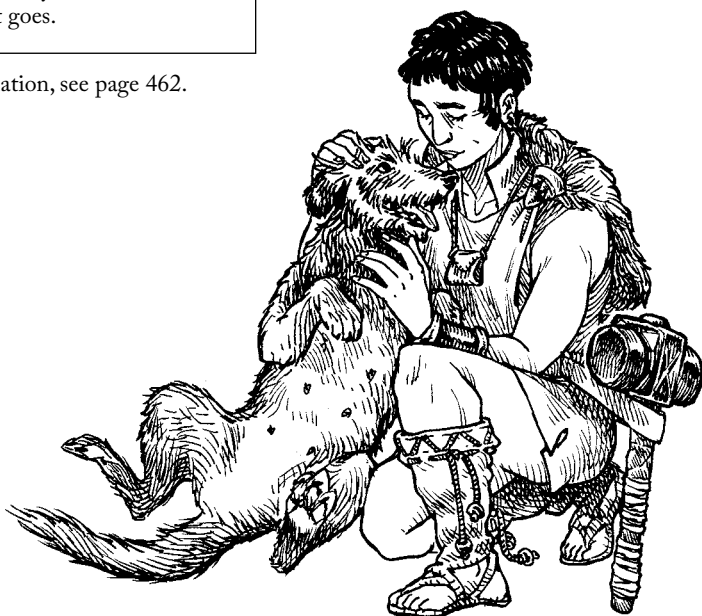
When you *pay your follower's cost*, and you haven't done so recently, they hold +1 Loyalty (max 3).

Spend your follower's Loyalty 1-for-1 to have them:

- ⊙ Overcome their fear to do as you say
- ⊙ Resist acting on their instinct/tags/traits
- ⊙ Do something they don't want to do (as long as it's not abhorrent or suicidal)

When a follower is without orders or they act on their own initiative, the GM says what they do and decides how it goes.

For more information, see page 464.



Expedition moves

These moves apply when you prepare for, undertake, or return from an expedition.

CHART A COURSE

When you *wish to travel to a distant place*, name or describe your destination (“Gordin’s Delve,” “the hagr’s lair,” or “wherever these tracks lead”). If the route is unclear, tell the GM how you intend to reach it. The GM will then tell you what’s required, the risks, and how long it will likely take.

When you *set out on the journey*, the GM will present each of the challenges one at a time—plus any surprises that you couldn’t have seen coming—in whatever order makes the most sense. Address them all and reach your destination.

For more information, see page 302.

OUTFIT

When you *prepare for an expedition in a friendly community*, mark as many ◇ on your Inventory insert as you wish to carry, either on specific items or in “undefined.” Mark up to 3◇ for a *light* load (quick and quiet), 4–6◇ for a *normal* load, or 7–9◇ for *heavy* load (noisy, slow, quick to tire). Also, mark a number of □ in the **Small items** section equal to 4+Prosperity (on specific items in “undefined”).

You can select...

- ⊙ Items printed on the Inventory insert
- ⊙ Other common, mundane items
- ⊙ Any of your personal possessions
- ⊙ Special items for which you Trade & Barter

Tell the GM what you’re bringing, and answer their questions about your gear and where you got it.

For more information, see page 306.

REQUISITION

When you *borrow some of the steading’s assets for an expedition* (like the horses or a plow), roll +Fortunes: on a 10+, go ahead, but bring it back safely; on a 7–9, you’ll need to do some convincing; on a 6–, don’t mark XP—you can take the asset with you if you want, but if you do, reduce Fortunes by 1.

For more information, see page 308.

Playing the Game

HAVE WHAT YOU NEED

When you *decide that you had something all along*, transfer a mark (or marks) from your “undefined” inventory to a specific item or a slot. If you mark a slot, fill it with a common mundane item or something from your personal possessions.

Alternately, you can expend a use of supplies to mark an additional small item/slot (□).

Whatever you produce, it must be something you could have had all along. The GM or any player can veto unreasonable items.

For more information, see page 326.

RECOVER

When you *take time to catch your breath and tend to what ails you*, expend 1 use of supplies and recover HP equal to 4+Prosperity. You can't gain this benefit again until you take more damage.

When you *tend to a debility or a problematic wound*, say how. The GM will either say that it's taken care of or tell you what's required to do so (Defying Danger, expending supplies or some other resource, finding ____, Making Camp, etc.).

For more information, see page 328.

STRUGGLE AS ONE

When you *Defy Danger as a group*, establish the party's approach and each roll +STAT (per Defy Danger): **on a 6-**, you find yourself in a spot, the GM will describe it or ask you to; **on a 7-9**, you pull your weight; **on a 10+**, you do well enough to get someone else out of a spot, if you can tell us how.

If you roll a 6- but someone saves you, don't mark XP.

For more information, see page 328.

KEEP COMPANY

When you *spend a stretch of time together*, ask the others if they want to Keep Company. If they do, take turns asking a PC or NPC one of the following.

- ④ What do you do that's annoying/endearing?
- ④ What do I do that you find annoying/endearing?
- ④ Who or what seems to be on your mind?
- ④ What do we find ourselves talking about?
- ④ How do you/we pass the time?
- ④ What new thing do you reveal about yourself?

For more information, see page 332.



MAKE CAMP

When you *settle in to rest in an unsafe area*, answer the GM's questions about your campsite. Each member of the party must consume 1 use of supplies or provisions; if you use a ◇ mess kit (*requires fire & water*), then 1 use can provide for up to four people.

If you *eat and drink your fill*, and *get at least a few hours of sleep*, pick 1.

- ⊙ Regain HP equal to ½ your max
- ⊙ Clear a debility

If *your rest was particularly peaceful, comfortable, or enjoyable*, you also gain advantage on your next roll.

For more information, see page 248 and page 334.

FORAGE

When you *spend a few hours seeking food in the wild*, roll +WIS. In winter, you have disadvantage. **On a 10+**, pick 2; **on a 7-9**, pick 1:

- ⊙ You acquire ♡ provisions (1d6 uses)
- ⊙ You acquire an extra 1d6 uses of provisions
- ⊙ You discover something interesting or useful
- ⊙ You avoid danger or risk (else, there is some)

Provisions can substitute for supplies when you Make Camp, 1-for-1.

For more information, see page 336.

RETURN TRIUMPHANT

When you *return home in triumph*, having saved your fellows, put down the threat, seized the opportunity, etc., then clear one of the steading's debilities (*diminished, lacking, or malcontent*). If the steading has no debilities marked, then increase Fortunes by 1.

For more information, see page 339.

Playing the Game

Homefront moves

These moves apply during downtime, or when you're interacting with a steading's population and resources.

BOLSTER

When you *prepare for what's coming or seek the favor of the gods*, say how and answer the GM's questions. Then, hold Preparation based on the amount of time you devote:

- ⊙ A week or so: 1 Preparation
- ⊙ A month or so: 2 Preparation
- ⊙ The better part of a season: 3 Preparation

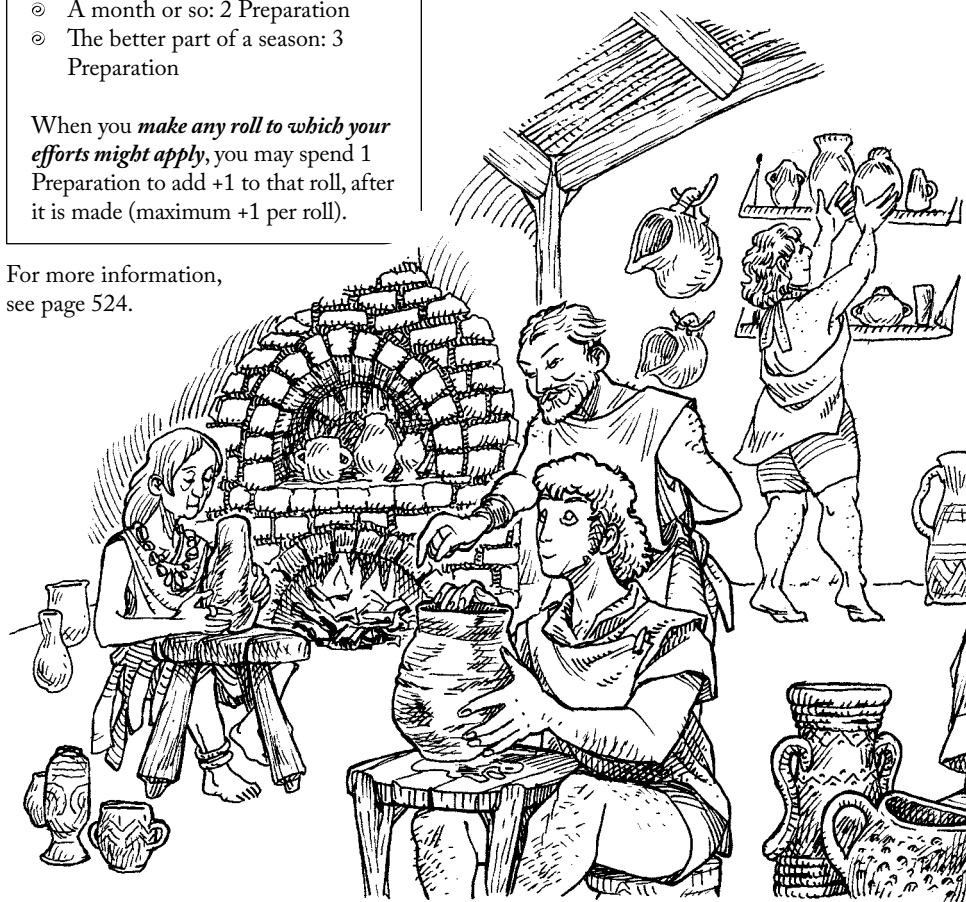
When you *make any roll to which your efforts might apply*, you may spend 1 Preparation to add +1 to that roll, after it is made (maximum +1 per roll).

For more information, see page 524.

CONVALESCE

When you *rest for a few days in safety and comfort*, set your HP back to your max and clear all your debilities. When you *rest for a few weeks under the care of a healer*, you heal any problematic wounds that can heal. If you *have suffered a permanent injury or impairment*, either retire or Make a Plan to adapt to it.

For more information, see page 249.



DEPLOY

When you *send a steading's people into danger or rally them against an attack*, roll +Defenses: **on a 10+**, it goes as well as can be expected; **on a 7-9**, it works but someone chooses 1 from the list below. If the steading is acting from a position of strength, you choose. Otherwise, the GM chooses.

- ⊙ It's less effective than you expected
- ⊙ Injuries abound; the steading marks *diminished* (disadvantage to Deploy, Muster, Pull Together)
- ⊙ The GM picks a named NPC involved in the action; they die

For more information, see page 526.



LEVEL UP

When you *have a quiet stretch of time at home and XP equal to (or greater than) 6 + twice your current level*, follow these steps:

- 1) Subtract 6 + twice your current level from your XP.
- 2) Increase your level by 1.
- 3) Choose a new move from your playbook, or an insert class that you've unlocked.
- 4) If you are the Blessed (or have a sacred pouch) and your new level is even, increase your max Stock by 1.
- 5) If you are the Lightbearer (or have Invoke the Sun God) and your new level is even, choose a new invocation.
- 6) Review your Instinct and Appearance (on the front of your playbook). Change anything that no longer applies. Feel free to make up new options.

For more information, see page 528.

MAKE A PLAN

When you *wish to accomplish some project but aren't sure how to go about it*, tell the GM what you hope to achieve. They'll say what's required. If you're stumped on how to accomplish one of the requirements, tell the GM and Make a Plan for that.

For more information, see page 530.

Playing the Game



MEET WITH DISASTER

When *calamity befalls the steading* or *panic spreads*, reduce Fortunes by 1 (min -1).

If *Fortunes would drop below -1 for any reason* (not just calamity or panic), then the GM picks 1 instead:

- ⊙ The steading marks *diminished* from injuries/sickness/doubt (disadvantage to Deploy, Muster, Pull Together)
- ⊙ The steading marks *lacking* due to shortages/hoarding/distrust (treat Prosperity as 1 lower)
- ⊙ The steading marks *malcontent* from fear/anger/despair (Fortunes reset to +0 each season, not +1; folks need Persuading more often than usual)
- ⊙ Folks start to leave; reduce Population by 1

MUSTER

When you *press every able body into the defense of a steading*, reduce Fortunes by 1 and roll +Population: **on a 7+**, the steading is alert and ready for action until the threat passes, the Seasons Change, or you cease to oversee the muster. **On a 10+**, also pick 2; **on a 7-9**, also pick 1.

- ⊙ Everyone's willing to pitch in; don't reduce Fortunes after all
- ⊙ The muster holds together even without your presence
- ⊙ 1 or 2 individuals show real potential; ask the GM who and how

For more information, see page 534.

For more information, see page 532.



PULL TOGETHER

When you *set a community to work on improvements, to secure new resources, or to make major repairs*, spend whatever the GM says is required (time, material, Surplus, etc.) and roll +Population: **on a 10+**, the job gets done; **on a 7-9**, pick 1:

- ⊙ It gets done, but other work doesn't; reduce Fortunes by 1
- ⊙ It gets done, but the work is shoddy, crude
- ⊙ It gets done, but there's a consequence (bad blood, an injury, a threat unearthed, etc.)
- ⊙ There's an unforeseen cost, requirement, or challenge; address it and the job gets done

For more information, see page 536.

TRADE & BARTER

When you *wish to acquire or sell a commonly available item*, you can.

When you *seek to acquire or sell a special item*, roll +Prosperity and subtract the item's Value. In winter, you have disadvantage. **On a 10+**, you can get it or sell it for a fair price; **on a 7-9 when you're trying to buy**, the GM picks 1:

- ⊙ You can get it, but it'll cost more than usual
- ⊙ ____ has it, but they aren't keen to give it up
- ⊙ You can get something close, but not quite right

On a 7-9 when you're looking to sell: you can sell it now, but you won't get its full worth.

On a 6- either way, don't mark XP. If you want to acquire/sell it, you'll need to travel to ____ or wait until next season.

For unique or truly exceptional items, don't Trade & Barter. Either get with the GM and Make a Plan or wait for a trade opportunity when Seasons Change.

For more information, see page 540.

Playing the Game

SEASONS CHANGE



When *spring bursts forth upon the land*, whoever is the most hopeful rolls +Fortunes: **on a 10+**, pick 1 seasonal gain; **on a 7-9**, pick 1 seasonal gain, but a threat to the steading makes itself known or gets worse; **on a 6-**, threats abound (and don't mark XP).

Whatever the result, reset Fortunes to +1.



When *the hot days of summer settle across the land*, whoever is most content rolls +Fortunes: **on a 10+**, pick 2 seasonal gains; **on a 7-9**, pick 1 seasonal gain; **on a 6-**, a threat to the steading makes itself known or gets worse (and don't mark XP).

Whatever the result, the steading generates 1d4-1 Surplus. Then, reset Fortunes to +1.



When *autumn falls and the land is ripe for harvest*, whoever is most determined rolls +Fortunes: **on a 10+**, pick 1 seasonal gain; **on a 7-9**, pick 1 seasonal gain, but a threat to the steading makes itself known or gets worse; **on a 6-**, threats abound (and don't mark XP).

Whatever the result, reset Fortunes to +1.

When *the harvest is complete*, roll 1d4; the steading generates that much Surplus.



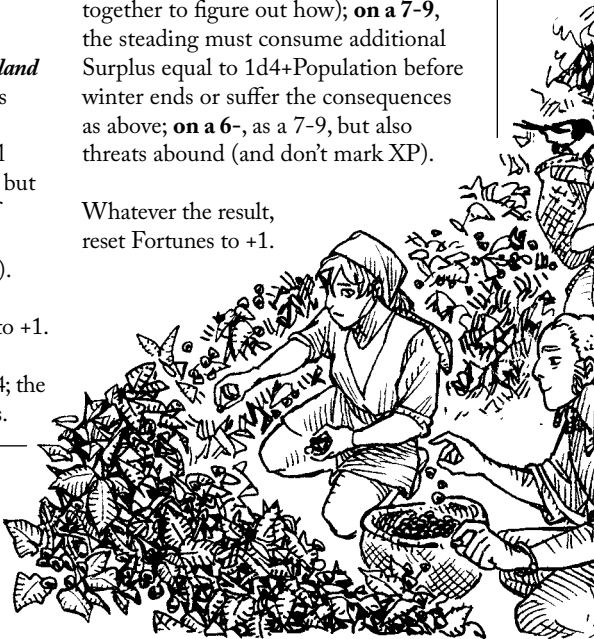
When *winter grips the land*, whoever is weariest rolls 1d4+Population; the steading consumes that much Surplus. If there's not enough, reduce Surplus to 0 and Meet with Disaster. Then, pick 1:

- ⊙ Reduce Population by 1 (min -1) due to death, decrepitude, and departure
- ⊙ An important resource (one of the horses, the cistern, etc.) is lost or not maintained
- ⊙ An important NPC dies, their role unfilled
- ⊙ Your PC dies, leaves, or retires from play

Then, roll +Fortunes: **on a 10+**, the winter is relatively mild, and each player can name a local NPC with whom their relationship improves at least a little (work together to figure out how); **on a 7-9**, the steading must consume additional Surplus equal to 1d4+Population before winter ends or suffer the consequences as above; **on a 6-**, as a 7-9, but also threats abound (and don't mark XP).

Whatever the result, reset Fortunes to +1.

For more information, see page 516.





Seasonal gains

- ⊙ **Population boom:** A number of youth come of age, and/or outsiders settle here. Increase Population by 1 (max +3).
- ⊙ **Tor's blessing:** Fine weather abounds. Take +1 to Pull Together this season, and any time you roll the Die of Fate for weather, roll twice and take your pick.
- ⊙ **Unexpected bounty:** A sudden influx of wild game, trade profits, or some other resource generates 1 Surplus, now.
- ⊙ **Trade opportunity:** At some point this season, someone offers to trade something valuable at a good price or something unique/unusual at a reasonable price. Pay what they're asking and it's yours.
- ⊙ **Interesting news:** There's an opportunity to improve your fortunes, knowledge, or relations, and/or to make progress towards a steading improvement.
- ⊙ **Valuable insight:** You learn something that gives you a chance to address a threat that's been plaguing the steading.



Gear and possessions

- ⊙ Your current inventory (the stuff you have on your person right now)
- ⊙ Your special possessions (the ones you start play with, and those that you acquire in play)

When you **Outfit** for an expedition (page 77), you'll fill out your Inventory insert. Mark the $\diamond$, $\diamond\diamond$, or $\square$ next to an item to indicate you are carrying it.

The insert also has blank spaces, where you can write in other common items or **special possessions** (see page 90).

When you **Outfit**, mark a number of $\diamond$ below, on specific items or Undefined.

- For a **light load** (*quick & quiet*), mark up to 3 $\clubsuit$
- For a **normal load**, mark 4-6 $\clubsuit$
- For a **heavy load** (*noisy*), mark 7-9 $\clubsuit$

- ⊙ For a **light load** (*quick & quiet*), mark up to 3 ✓
- ⊙ For a **normal load**, mark 4-6 ✓
- ⊙ For a **heavy load** (mark 7-9) ✓

For a normal load, mark 4-6 ☒

defined ☒ ☒ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

Undefined ☒ ☒ ☒ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

When you **Have What You Need**, move ☒ from here to ☐ below.

☒ **Supplies** (4+Prosperity uses ○○○○○○)

- ◆ More supplies (4+ Prosperity uses ○○○○○○)
- ◆ Even more

Use supplies to Recover, Make Camp, or h

Use supplies to Recover, Make Camp, or have extra *small* items.

- ✦ **Mess kit** (requires fire & water; makes Supplies last longer)
- ✦ **Bedroll** (recover 1d6 extra HP when you Make Camp)
- ✦ **Blanket** (*warm*)
- ✦ **Rope**, ~25 ft

- ✓ **Bedroll** (recover 1d6 extra HP when you Make Camp)
- ◇ **Blanket** (*warm*)
- ◇ **Rope**, ~25 ft

☒ Change of clothes
☐ Shovel

Shovel

□ **Snow-shoes**

- ☒ **Torch** (lasts ~1 hour; *reach, area, dangerous*)
- ☐ **Oil lamp** (○○○ hours, *reach* ...)
- ☐ **Extra oil** (○○○ ...)

- ◆ Oil lamp (○○○○ hours, reach, area, danger)
- ◆ Extra oil (○○○○○ hours, reach, area, crude)
- ◆ Firewood (○○○○○ hours, reach, area, danger)

- ◆◆◆◆◆ **Extra oil** (00000 hours, for lamp/lantern, useless as a weapon)
- ◆◆◆◆◆ **Firewood** (enough to last 1 full night)
- ◆◆◆◆◆ **Hatchet**, iron (1 full night, area, dangerous)

- ◆ **Hatchet**, iron (*hand, thrown*, x piercing)
- ◆ **Mallet**, iron and/or wood (*hand*)
- ◆ **Mattock**, iron

◇ **Mattock** iron (hand)

- ♦♦ **Mattok**, iron (*close*, x piercing, messy, asul)
- ♦♦ **Maul**, iron (*close for*, *asul*)
- ♦♦ **Stoff**, (*close for*, *asul*)

Staff, iron (close for pricing, messy and

Fit in a pocket, pouch, or boot.
When you

When you **Outfit**, mark ☐ below
equal to 4+Prosperity.

Undefined ☒ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

When you ***Have What You Need***,
move ☒ from here to items below,
or expend supplies to mark an
additional ☐.

☒ Knife or dagger, iron (hand)
☐ Sling (near, reload)

- ☐ **Sling** (near, reload, awkward, low ammo, all out)
- ☐ **Rushlight** (1)

- ☐ **Rushlight** (lasts ~15-30 minutes, *close, crude*)
- ☒ **Tinder**

- ☒ **Tinderbox** (*slow*)
- ☐ **Needle**

- ☐ Needle & thread
- ☐ Handful of coppers
- ☐ Whisk

☐ Whistful of coppers



Load

Items that have a ◇ or ◇◇ in front of them contribute to your load. Count the total number of ◇ that you have marked. If you have...

- ... up to 3 ♡, then you have a **light load**, able to move quick and quiet;
- ... 4 to 6 ♡, then you have a **normal load**;
- ... 7 to 9 ♡, then you have a **heavy load**—you're noisy, slow, hot, and quick to tire.

You (Caradoc, the apprentice tanner, impetuous youth, and Would-be Hero) Outfit for an expedition to the Ruined Tower, marking your Inventory as shown on the opposite page. You have 6 ♡, which means that you're carrying a normal load. You are traveling with Vahid (the Seeker, a different PC); he's also carrying a normal load (6 ♡), but he's carrying different items (of course).

Your load has no specific effect, but it's part of your **fictional positioning** (page 42). For example, the GM might say, "Vahid, you're carrying a heavy load, right? That seems like Defying Danger to me, the danger being that you exhaust yourself in this heat." Or, "Ooh, a 7? Well, you slip past without them getting spotted, but your gear jingles and one of them looks up, suspicious. She's coming to investigate. What do you do?"

If you carry 10 ♡ or more, or something very heavy or awkward, then not only do you have a heavy load but you risk exhaustion, accident, and injury. The GM will tell you the consequences and/or requirements of being overloaded.

If you use up or discard any items, or give them to someone else, then clear the ♡ next to them. They no longer count towards your load.

If you pick up any items in the field (like loot), or if an ally gives some of their gear to you, add it to your Inventory, marking the appropriate ◇. This might change your load!

You and Vahid arrive at the Ruined Tower that night, and you use up your ♡ ♡ firewood. You're down to 4 ♡ total, which is still a normal load.

The next morning, you leave your ♡ shovel with Vahid at the campsite and explore the upper levels of the ruin. You're now carrying only 3 ♡ total, so you have a light load and you're able to move about quietly.

You discover a ◇◇ half-buried plaque in the courtyard, made of bronze and etched with Maker-runes. The coast appears to be clear, so you go get Vahid and your ♡ shovel. You spend a few minutes digging the plaque out of the dirt. Vahid confirms that it's a valuable artifact, so you bring it with you. You add "♡ ♡ bronze plaque" to a blank line of your Inventory insert, and you're back up to 6 ♡ total.

All that digging, though, draws the attention of a beznpol—a great big armored stoat! After a quick but bloody fight, you kill it! Its scales sure seem valuable, so you skin the beast and add "♡ beznpol hide" to your Inventory. You're now at 7 ♡ total, which is a heavy load.

Playing the Game

Small items

A small item is something that could fit in a pocket, pouch, or boot with room to spare. Small items do not contribute to your load. Track them on the right side of your Inventory insert, in the “Small items” section.

When you **Outfit** (page 77), you can mark a number of small items equal to 4 plus Stonetop’s current Prosperity (+0 by default). If you want more small items, then bring **supplies** (page 89).

If you acquire a new small item on an expedition, add it to your Inventory in one of the blanks in the Small items section. There’s no hard limit to the number of small items you can carry, but be reasonable. If you start stockpiling, the GM might say that your small items count as  or even   in aggregate.

When you Outfitted for your trip to the Ruined Tower, you marked 4 small items (because Stonetop’s Prosperity is currently +0).

As you explored the upper levels, you found a jagged shard of makerglass, sharp as anything and impossible to break. It’s not much bigger than a coin, a small item. You pack it into your tinderbox, and add “ makerglass shard” to your Inventory insert.

Undefined items

You don’t have to define your items up front. When you **Outfit** (page 77), you can put some or all of your marks in the “Undefined” areas of your Inventory insert. These represent items that your PC has on their person, but which you (the player) have not yet established in the fiction.

At any point, you can **Have What You Need** (page 78) and transfer marks from one of the two “Undefined” areas to a specific item. The specific item can be anything already printed on the Inventory insert, any common, mundane item, or any of your special possessions—but it must be something you could have had with you all along.

The idea is: **don’t waste time at the table fretting over what specific items you might need to bring.** Mark only items that you know you want to bring, and then put all your other marks in “Undefined.” Your PC is a competent person who knows about the world they live in, and what they might need for any given journey.

When you Outfitted, you marked  supplies, a  shovel,   firewood, and undefined  . Under “Small items,” you marked a  dagger, a  tinderbox, the  locket with Morwenna’s hair (a special possession), and undefined .

As you explored the upper levels of the Ruined Tower, you turned your last undefined mark under “Small items” into chalk, leaving marks as you explored.

When the beznpol attacked, you turned one of your undefined  into a  spear.

Supplies

Near the top of your Inventory insert, you'll find "◇ Supplies" (and "◇ More supplies" and "◇ Even more supplies").

"Supplies" represent the essentials that you might bring with you on expedition: food, water, bandages, salves, whisky, additional small items, etc.

By default, one ◇ of supplies contains 4 uses, but you add Stonetop's current **Prosperity** (page 66) to that. So if Stonetop's Prosperity is currently +1, then each ◇ of supplies contains 5 uses instead of 4.

Use supplies to:

- ⊙ **Recover** (page 78)
- ⊙ **Make Camp** (page 79)
- ⊙ **Have What You Need** (page 78) to produce additional small items
- ⊙ Feed yourself as you travel.

By default, each person on an expedition consumes 1 use of supplies per day. But, if you have a ◇ mess kit (which requires water and fire), then 1 use of supplies can cover up to four people.

After your fight with the beznpol, you're bleeding from a few dozen cuts and scratches. You spend 1 use of supplies to Recover, regaining 4 HP. You've got 3 uses of supplies left.

"What's this look like?" asks the GM.

Vahid pipes in. "I'll clean your wounds with water and a little whisky, then wrap them up in bandages. And, here, drink what's left of the whisky. It will take the edge off the pain."

Provisions

If you're low on supplies, you can **Forage** (page 336) and acquire up to 2d6 uses of ♡ provisions. You might also gain them incidentally (if, say, you fight an angry boar and harvest the meat).

Expend provisions in place of supplies when you Make Camp, or to feed yourself as you travel. Provisions, though, are more likely to spoil or attract beasts than supplies are.

*You've skinned the beznpol, and it seems wasteful to just leave the flesh. You **Know Things** (page 72) to see if they're good eating, and get a 7. "Well, you don't know about beznpol," says the GM, "but hunters will often eat the liver or heart of a beast fresh after the kill. That'd count as, oh, 3 uses of provisions. But you'll have to roll the Die of Fate to see if it makes you sick."*

You're an impetuous youth, and Vahid is curious to a fault, so you each eat a use of provisions when you Make Camp rather than using up supplies. You get a 6 on the Die of Fate, so, yeah, it's rather tasty and neither of you gets ill.

You've still got 1 use of provisions left, but it's not like raw liver or heart keeps well. You toss what's left to the crows instead of adding it to your Inventory.

Back home

When you return home, clear the marks from your Inventory insert; it rarely matters what you're carrying while you're in town. If it does matter, assume that you have a light load (up to 3 ♡) and a handful of small items unless there's a good reason to think otherwise.

Playing the Game

Special possessions

Your special possessions are the things that you own or have access to, but which others do *not*. A shield, spear, a cloak, a pair of snow shoes, a cookpot—every household has these, so they are common items. But few (if any) folks in town possess a sword, or parchment and ink, or an anvil, tongs, and bellows. Any of those would be special possessions.

You acquire special possessions by...

- ... choosing them when you create your character;
- ... naturally, through play (as loot, as a gift or reward, etc.); and
- ... **Trading & Bartering** (page 83).

Track your special possessions on your Inventory insert, in an appropriate blank. You can **Outfit** (page 77) with them, or **Have What You Need** (page 78) to mark them once you're in the field. Like any item, they count against your load (if they have a ◇ or ◇◇) and your starting number of small items.

If a special possession is something that you wouldn't carry on your person (like a herd of goats or an anvil), then record it at the bottom of your Inventory insert, under "Other things."

Initial special possessions

When you make your character, you'll choose special possessions from your playbook. Most of these choices include a list of items, which you own or have ready access to. Assume that you're proficient with these items.

Items listed in the plural ("thick gloves") or general ("lime") are things that you have a reasonable amount of, and can make or acquire more over time. An item listed in the singular (like "a ◇ boiled leather cuirass") is the only one you've got; if you lose it, it's gone until you replace it.

A special possession with a number of uses is a finite resource. Once expended, those uses are gone (even if the item itself remains). If you want more uses, **Make a Plan** (page 81) with the GM.

One of Vahid's special possessions is "Books & scrolls (○○○○○ uses): expend a use to consult your collection and turn a Know Things roll you just made into a 10+." After Vahid marks the fifth circle, he can no longer use his collection to change the results of a Know Things roll. He still has the books and scrolls, but they no longer modify a move.

If you're a Seeker, add your arcana to your Inventory sheet, too! If they have a ◇ or ◇◇ on the front side, they count towards your load, as always. Otherwise, they're small items, or something that you wouldn't carry around with you.

Possessions gained in play

When you acquire a new item in play, add it to your Inventory insert in the appropriate spot. When you return home, leave it on your insert. It's now one of your special possessions; you can mark it when you **Outfit** or **Have What You Need**.

You can, of course, freely discard a new special possession, or give it away, or trade it to another PC. But if you want to sell it to an NPC, you must roll to **Trade & Barter** (page 83).

You and Vahid trudge home. You've still got that makerglass shard, the ♡♡ bronze plaque, and the ♡ beznopol hide.

You keep the makerglass shard on your Inventory sheet (it's neat!), but give the bronze plaque (a minor arcanum) to Vahid. You erase it from your Inventory sheet; he adds it to his. You keep the beznopol hide on your insert for now, but you might try to trade it away later.

Trade & Barter

Commonly available items—things on the Inventory insert, or that could be found in pretty much any Stonetop household—are readily available. Folks trade, loan, and gift these items all the time, and it's not worth tracking them. See page 95 for a list of example **common items**.

To acquire or sell a special item, though, you must roll to **Trade & Barter** (page 83). The result tells you whether you can make the trade easily and fairly (on a 10+), or if there's a catch (on a 7-9), or if the trade just isn't going to happen here and now.

See page 96 for a list of **special items**. For items not on the list, the GM decides whether there's any chance of finding it (or finding a buyer for it). If not, don't roll to Trade & Barter; **Make a Plan** (page 81) with the GM instead.

Value

The world of *Stonetop* has no central government, no common currency, and no standard exchange rates. So, what constitutes a fair trade?

To help answer that question, items and services are given a Value from 0 to 4. Value is more of a logarithmic scale than linear. A single Value 2 item is worth maybe a dozen or so Value 1 items. Three individual Value 1 items don't add up to Value 3; they're just three Value 1 items.

When you roll a 10+ to Trade & Barter, "a fair price" means you're trading within the same Value, but the exchange might not be 1:1. It might be 2:1 or even 3:1 if you're trading some common, local resource for a desirable or imported good (or vice versa).

If you roll a 7-9 to Trade & Barter, you might have to pay more or settle for less than usual. That often means a better or worse exchange rate (2:1 instead of 1:1, for example), but it could mean trading across Value tiers.

Regardless: if you don't like the exchange rate that you're getting, you can try to Persuade the other party to change their minds. Good luck!

Playing the Game



Sawyl the tanner (your boss) confirms that beznpol hide is indeed valuable. “It’s Value 2,” says the GM, “but with a pair of hides, Sawyl could craft a suit of magnificent armor worth Value 3.”

You’ve no desire to tangle with another beznpol, so you look to trade the hide away. This triggers Trade & Barter. On a 10+, the GM might say that there’s a merchant in town who offers a pouch of silvers (also Value 2). On a 7–9, that same merchant might offer only a Value 1 item (like a fine steel spear), as beznpol hide isn’t a hot commodity.

Alas, you roll a 6–, so the GM says “No one here is interested, and no merchants are due until autumn. But you could go out to Titan Bones and talk to the Hill-folk. Their heroes wear beznpol armor. They wouldn’t give you a grown horse—that’s Value 3—but you could probably get a couple of Value 2 items.”

Exchange rates are far from standard, but...

A Value 0 item is generally worth:

- ⊙ A ◇ purse of copper coins
- ⊙ A single silver coin
- ⊙ A favor
- ⊙ A few days of unskilled labor
- ⊙ A common, mundane item

A Value 1 item is generally worth:

- ⊙ A handful of silver coins
- ⊙ A season (or so) of unskilled labor
- ⊙ A few days of skilled labor
- ⊙ A unit of trade goods* (sack of grain, ◇ pouch of salt, ◇◇ stack of pelts, etc.)
- ⊙ A bit of finery (◇ richly embroidered cloak, a silk scarf, silver comb, etc.)

A Value 2 item is generally worth:

- ⊙ A ◇ purse of silver coins
- ⊙ A **Surplus** (page 67)
- ⊙ A single gold coin
- ⊙ A year (or so) of unskilled labor
- ⊙ A season (or so) of skilled labor
- ⊙ A cartload of trade goods*
- ⊙ An item of luxury or status (gold ring, artful silver torc, gemstone, etc.)



A Value 3 item is generally worth:

- ⊙ A handful of gold coins
- ⊙ A year (or so) of skilled labor
- ⊙ A good, trained horse or mule
- ⊙ A precious item (ruby ring, gold torc, etc.)

A Value 4 item is generally worth:

- ⊙ A ◇ purse of gold coins
- ⊙ A dozen or so good horses
- ⊙ A “priceless” item (huge flawless gemstone, ◇ gold statuette, ◇ bejeweled scepter, etc.)

* Exotic trade goods (like silks, spices, and the like) are +1 Value

Commonly available items are Value 0, as are some special items like a bronze spear, a lantern, or a writing slate. Such special items aren't really valuable, but they aren't common, either, so you must still roll to Trade & Barter to see if you can acquire one. If you can, you can (likely) trade some commonly available item or a favor for it, or just borrow it.

Coins

Stonetop doesn't mint coins, and folks don't use them day-to-day. The local economy runs on trade, gifts and favors, debt and honor. Coin is used almost exclusively when trading with outsiders.

Even then, coin is worth only what folks will trade for it. There's no government to set or enforce prices or exchange rates. Coins vary greatly in size, weight, and purity. Coins minted in Gordin's Delve might be worth more to locals than to outsiders. A Lygosi merchant might prefer southern currency to old Maker coins, but an antiquarian might consider those ancient coins to be priceless.

Stonetop abstracts coinage into individual coins, handfuls, and ◇ purses. Coins are most often copper, silver, or gold.

- ⊙ **An individual coin** is quite small, ranging in size from a that of a modern penny to a silver dollar.
- ⊙ **A handful of coins** contains about 10 individual coins.
- ⊙ **A ◇ purse of coins** contains about 10 handfuls of coins, or around 100 individual coins.
- ⊙ **One silver coin** is roughly worth a ◇ purse of coppers (around 100 copper coins, Value 0).
- ⊙ **One gold coin** is roughly worth a ◇ purse of silvers (around 100 silver coins, or an absolute pile of coppers, Value 2).

Playing the Game

Gear terms & tags

Many items appear with a list of terms after their name, in parentheses.

Terms in *italic* typeface are **tags**. They have no specific mechanical effect, but they are part of **fictional positioning** (page 42). The most common tags are listed here, but others are certainly possible.

Terms in regular typeface are mechanical, interacting with other rules or game elements. Again, the most common terms are listed below, but some items have unique rules associated with them.

◇ or ◇◇: it takes up one of these slots on your Inventory insert, and counts against your load.

area: affects everything in an area.

[*n*] armor: when you take damage, subtract *n*; doesn't stack.

+1 armor: increases your armor value by 1; stacks.

awkward: unwieldy, requires space, gets stuck.

crude: prone to break, wear out, stop working, etc.

cumbersome: you're noisy, slow, hot, and quick to tire while carrying it, even without a heavy load (and if you have a heavy load, it's worse).

+*[n]* damage: increase the damage you deal with that weapon by *n*.

dangerous: causes trouble and collateral damage if you aren't careful (and maybe if you are).

forceful: can knock someone around, maybe even off their feet.

fragile: easy to break/ruin; pack it carefully.

hours: it lasts about an hour for each ○; mark ○ to track time used.

immobile: you can't really carry it on your person; you need a beast or vehicle to transport it.

messy: does particularly destructive damage, ripping people and things apart.

[*n*] piercing: when you deal damage, ignore *n* points of the target's armor. For "*x* piercing" items, *x* = the steading's current Prosperity.

reload: after it's used, it takes time/effort to reset.

requires ____: if you don't meet the requirements, it works poorly or not at all.

slow: takes minutes or more to use; unlikely to be useful in a fight.

thrown: you can Let Fly with it (at *near* range).

uses: mark a ○ each time you use it; it's gone/useless when they're all marked.

warm: will keep you warm in cold weather, but it's uncomfortable and exhausting (and possibly dangerous) in hot weather.

Range Tags

These indicate the distance within which a weapon/light source is effective.

hand: tight quarters; up close and personal.

close: melee range, 1-2 steps away.

reach: 3-4 steps away.

near: up to 30 or so steps away.

far: quite the distance; up to 100 steps, maybe more.

Ammo

Many ranged weapons have one or more of these statuses:

○ plenty left, ○ low ammo, ○ all out

When you deplete your ammo (because a move tells you to, or the GM says so), mark the next available status (left to right). When you mark "☑ all out," you're out of ammo and can't use that weapon until you replenish your ammunition.

Common items

The following are commonly available, mundane items. You can **Outfit** (page 77) with them, or **Have What You Need** (page 78). You don't need to roll anything to acquire them, though the GM might ask where you got them.

WEAPONS

	VALUE
◇ Bow & iron arrows (<i>near</i> , <i>x</i> piercing, ○ low ammo, ○ all out)	0
◇ Extra arrows (<i>x</i> piercing, ○ plenty left, ○ low ammo, ○ all out)	0
◇ Hatchet , iron (<i>hand</i> , <i>thrown</i> , <i>x</i> piercing)	0
◇ Javelins , a few, iron (<i>thrown</i> , <i>x</i> piercing, +1 damage, ○ all out)	0
Knife or dagger , iron (<i>hand</i>)	0
◇◇ Long spear , iron (<i>reach</i> , <i>x</i> piercing)	0
◇ Mallet , iron or wood (<i>hand</i>)	0
◇ Mattock , iron (<i>close</i> , <i>messy</i> , <i>x</i> piercing, <i>awkward</i>)	0
◇◇ Maul , iron (<i>close</i> , <i>forceful</i> , <i>awkward</i>)	0
Sling (<i>near</i> , <i>reload</i> , <i>awkward</i> , ○ low ammo, ○ all out)	0
◇ Spear , iron (<i>close</i> , <i>thrown</i> , <i>x</i> piercing)	0
◇ Staff (<i>close</i>)	0

ARMOR

	VALUE
◇◇ Shield (+1 armor, +1 Readiness on a 7+ to Defend)	0
◇◇ Thick hides (1 armor, <i>warm</i>)	0

CLOTHING

	VALUE
◇ Change of clothes	0
◇ Cloak (<i>warm</i>)	0
Extra socks	0
Gloves	0
Needle & thread	0

FIRE & LIGHT SOURCES

	VALUE
◇ Extra oil , for lamp/lantern (○○○○○ hours, useless as a weapon)	0
◇◇ Firewood (enough for 1 full night, <i>reach</i> , <i>area</i>)	0
◇ Oil lamp (○○○ hours, <i>close</i> , <i>area</i> , <i>crude</i>)	0
Rushlight (lasts ~15-30 minutes, <i>hand</i> , <i>crude</i>)	0
Tinderbox (<i>slow</i>)	0
◇ Torch (lasts ~1 hour, <i>reach</i> , <i>area</i> , <i>dangerous</i>)	0

TRAVEL GEAR

	VALUE
◇ Bedroll (recover 1d6 extra HP when you Make Camp)	0
◇ Blanket (<i>warm</i>)	0
Bowstring , spare	0
Handful of copper coins	0
◇ Mess kit (requires fire & water)	0
◇ Rope , ~25 feet	0
Sack (empty)	0
◇◇ Sledge/litter/travois , roll-out	0
◇ Snowshoes	0
◇ Supplies (see page 89)	0
Waterskin	0
Whetstone	0
Whisky , skin (○○ uses)	0
Whistle	0

HOUSEHOLD GOODS

	VALUE
Awl	0
Chalk	0
Charcoal	0
Clay jar	0
Cloth/rag	0
Comb	0
Cup	0
Little box	0
Sawdust	0
◇ Shovel	0
Tallow	0
Twine/cord	0

Playing the Game

Special items

If you want to acquire any of these items, you must roll to **Trade & Barter** (page 83), and on a 7+ you must trade something of appropriate Value (which might be a favor or a debt). The GM will tell you what the other party wants.

WEAPONS OF WAR	VALUE
◇ Mace or flail , iron (<i>close, forceful</i>)	1
◇ Battleaxe , iron (<i>close, messy</i>)	1*
◇ Short sword , iron (<i>hand, close</i>)	1*
◇ Sword , iron (<i>close, +1 damage</i>)	1*
◇ Warhammer , iron (<i>close, 2 piercing</i>)	1
◇ Crossbow (<i>far, +1 damage, x piercing, reload, ○ low ammo, ○ all out</i>)	1
◇ Composite bow (<i>far, +1 damage, x piercing, ○ low ammo, ○ all out</i>)	1*

*Value 2 to get 1 piercing or (maybe) 2 piercing

BRONZE WEAPONS*	VALUE
Common weapons (spears, daggers, etc.)	0
Weapons of war (see above)	1

*Bronze weapons do not have "x piercing"

ARMOR	VALUE
◇ Cuirass , boiled leather (1 armor)	1
◇◇ Hauberk/cuirass/scale , iron or bronze (2 armor, <i>warm, cumbersome</i>)	2
◇ Vest , brigandine, fancy (2 armor, <i>warm</i>)	3

LIGHT SOURCES	VALUE
Candle (lasts ~1 hour, <i>close, area</i>)	0
◇ Lantern (○○○○○ hours, <i>close, area</i>)	0
◇ Bullseye lantern (○○○○○ hours, <i>near</i>)	1

TOOLS & TRADES	VALUE
Small metal tool (chisel, file, shears, etc.)	0
Glass vial (<i>fragile</i>)	0
◇ Block & tackle	0
◇ Instrument (harp, lute, fiddle, etc.)	1
◇ Metal tools (drill, prybar, saw, etc.)	0
◇ Mirror , hand-held, polished bronze	1
Common trade tools (for pottery, weaving, distilling, etc.; <i>immobile</i>)	1
Uncommon trade tools (for carpentry, chandlery, beekeeping, etc.; <i>immobile</i>)	2
Specialized trade tools (for smithing, glassblowing, scribing, etc.; <i>immobile</i>)	3

WRITING IMPLEMENTS	VALUE
◇ Slate and chalk	0
◇ Wax tablet and stylus	0
Parchment , a few sheets (<i>fragile</i>)	1
Fine vellum , a few sheets (<i>fragile</i>)	2
Ink, vial and quills	1
◇ Empty book, parchment (<i>fragile</i>)	1
◇ Empty book, fine vellum (<i>fragile</i>)	2

Playing the Game

TRANSPORT	VALUE
Wheelbarrow	1
Cart or sleigh (requires donkey/mule/horse)	2
Wagon (requires mule/horse)	3
Spare parts for wagon/cart/sleigh (axles, wheels, etc.; ○○○ uses, <i>immobile</i>)	2
EXOTIC STUFF	VALUE
Bendis root (fumes repel perversions of nature; lasts ~1 hour, <i>reach, area</i>)	1
Bezoar (swallow to cure any poison)	1
◇ Naphtha (burns hot & sticky; damage d8; ○○○ uses, <i>thrown, area, dangerous</i> , ignores armor)	1
◇ Silver-alloy dagger (<i>hand</i>)	2
TRADE GOODS	VALUE
Salt (a little box)	0
Skin of whisky , fine (○○ uses; share a use with someone to get advantage on Persuade)	0
◇ Purse of coppers (~10 handfuls)	0
◇◇ Firkin of whisky , fine	1
Handful of silvers	1
Barrel of whisky , common (<i>immobile</i>)	1
Barrel of whisky , fine (<i>immobile</i>)	2
◇ Purse of silvers (~10 handfuls)	2
1 Surplus of various trade goods (<i>immobile</i>)	2

LIVESTOCK & OTHER BEASTS	VALUE
Dog , follower (<i>keen-nosed</i> , pick 2 more) HP 6; Damage d6 (<i>band, grabby</i>); Instinct to get distracted; Cost training	1
Goat (<i>sure-footed, curious, hungry</i>) HP 3; Damage d4 (<i>band</i>); Instinct to explore; butcher for ◇ provisions (○○○○○○ uses)	1
Sheep (<i>timid, hardy, wooly</i>) HP 3; Damage d4 (<i>band</i>); Instinct to follow the herd; butcher for ◇ provisions (○○○○○○ uses)	1
Pig (<i>keen-nosed, stubborn, gluttonous, clever</i>) HP 6; Damage d4 (<i>band</i>); Instinct to eat anything; butcher for ◇ provisions (d6+10 uses)	1
Donkey (<i>hardy, sure-footed, cautious, slow</i>) HP 10; Damage d4+2 (<i>band, forceful</i>); Instinct to be stubborn	2
Mule , follower? (<i>large, hardy, sure-footed, cautious, keen-nosed, sterile</i>) HP 14; Damage d6+1 (<i>band, close</i>); Instinct to avoid danger; Cost care & grooming	3
Horse , follower? (<i>large, powerful, keen-nosed, swift or hardy</i>) HP 10; Damage d6+3 (<i>band, close, forceful</i>); Instinct to panic; Cost care & grooming	3

If you want to...

Here are some things you might want to do, and how you might go about them.

...increase Fortunes

The main ways are:

- ⊙ Undertake an expedition on behalf of the village and **Return Triumphant** (page 79).
- ⊙ Complete a stading improvement that increases Fortunes.

...gain Surplus

The village generates Surplus each summer and at the end of autumn when the harvest is complete. If you want more:

- ⊙ Choose “unexpected bounty” when you get a **seasonal gain** (page 85).
- ⊙ Choose “trade opportunity” when you get a seasonal gain, and suggest that you’d like to trade for extra Surplus.
- ⊙ Undertake an expedition to hunt big game: elk, wisents, cave bears, ceirwmawr, etc.
- ⊙ Buy some! Surplus isn’t commonly available, so you’ll need to **Trade & Barter** (page 83) to see if it’s available from a passing merchant. If it’s not, you’ll need to travel to a neighboring stading. Surplus is Value 2, so expect to pay a purse of silvers, a donkey, a barrel of fine whisky, or so forth.

If you want to increase the amount of Surplus that the village generates, look to the stading improvements.



...improve Defenses

You can temporarily boost Defenses via the **Muster** move (page 82), but it will usually cost you Fortunes to do so. Other options include:

- ⊙ Build a **Palisade** (page 158) or a **Stone Wall** (page 159). They grant advantage to Deploy rolls when you take advantage of them.
- ⊙ Establish a **Standing Watch** (page 159). They add +1 to your Defenses when they're involved.
- ⊙ Spend time drilling the villagers, turning them into a **Well-Trained Militia** (page 159). If you train the militia in 2 or more tactics, Defenses increases by 1.
- ⊙ Furnish the village with **Weapons of War** (page 159) and teach folks to use them. This increases Defenses by 1 and gives PCs access to better weaponry.

...increase Population

Choose "population boon" when you get a **seasonal gain** (page 85).

Alternatively, go out and save or recruit or capture a bunch of people and bring them back to live in your village.

Careful: higher Population makes it easier to **Muster** (page 82) and **Pull Together** (page 83), but it also means more mouths to feed in winter when **Seasons Change** (page 84).

...improve Prosperity

Pursue the **Expanded Trades** (page 157) and/or the **Market** (page 158) improvement. Each of these increase Prosperity by 1, as long as they're maintained.

Also, the **Township** improvement (page 159) grants advantage when you **Trade & Barter** (page 83).

Playing the Game

...unlock a steading improvement

Look at the requirements and choose one to pursue. If you don't know how to pursue it, **Know Things** (page 72) and/or **Make a Plan** (page 81).

If you want to make an improvement to the steading that isn't listed, tell the GM what you have in mind. They'll either Make a Plan with you or add it to the list of Other Improvements (along with the requirements and potential benefits), whichever is more appropriate.

...get some coin

You can **Outfit** (page 77) or **Have What You Need** (page 78) to produce a handful of coppers, but if you want more significant quantities, or any quantity of silver or gold coins, then you'll need to roll **Trade & Barter** (page 83) to see if they're even available. Even if they are, you'll need to trade something of an appropriate Value.

Other options include:

- ⊙ If you need more coin than what's available in town, you can undertake a trade mission. Take some of the steading's Surplus to Marshedge, Gordin's Delve, or maybe the Hillfolk, and find someone to buy it. A purse or two of silvers is a fair trade for 1 Surplus (Value 2).
- ⊙ Go explore the Ruined Tower or someplace like it and dig up some sweet loot. Then roll Trade & Barter to sell it to a passing merchant or head to Marshedge or Gordin's Delve and try to sell it there for more.

...find new arcana

Know Things (page 72)! Maybe you know where something like that might be found. If you don't, try something else:

- ⊙ Ask around, dig through the Chronicle (if there is one), consult the spirits (if you can), pray for guidance (if that's your thing), eat some mushrooms and hope for a vision, etc.
- ⊙ Explore dangerous, mysterious places: old Maker-ruins, barrow mounds, Fae circles, strange groves, caves, or lakes (if you dare).
- ⊙ Put the word out. Let merchants and other contacts know that you're interested in that sort of thing, then choose "trade opportunity" or "interesting news" when you get a **seasonal gain** (page 85).

...unlock the mysteries of an arcanum

Do what the requirements say! If you're not sure how to meet a requirement, roll to **Know Things** (page 72) and/or talk to the GM and **Make a Plan** (page 81).

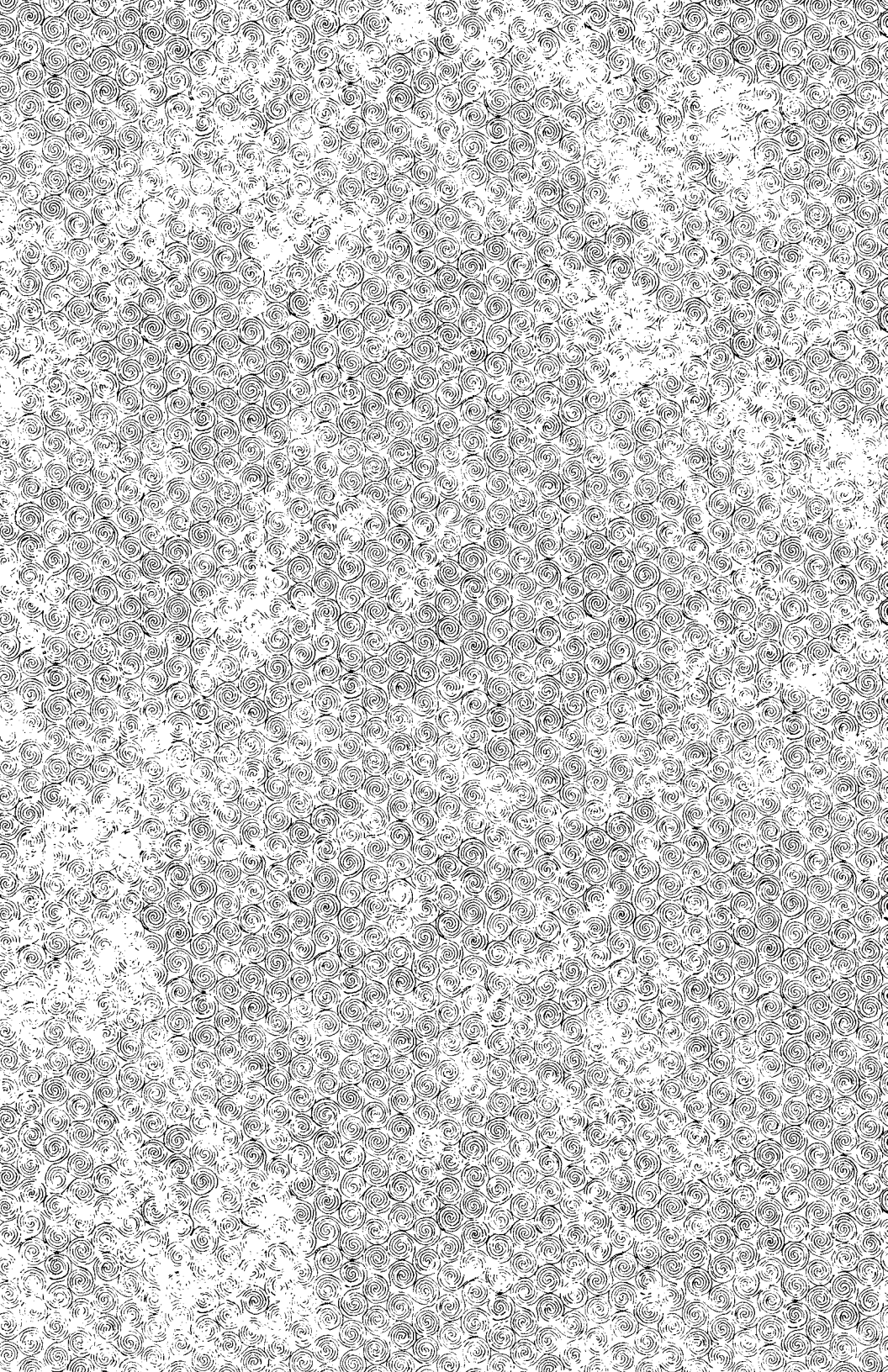
...recruit followers

If you have someone in mind, ask them to join you on an expedition. **Persuade** them if necessary (page 73).

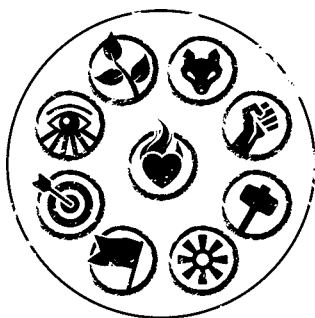
If you don't have someone in mind, tell the GM what sort of follower you're looking for ("a skilled tracker," "a knowledgeable guide," "someone who can handle themselves in a fight," etc.). They'll either tell you who in town fits the bill, or ask you to make someone up, or suggest that you **Know Things** (page 72).

Alternatively:

- ⊙ **Muster** (page 82) and pick "1 or 2 individuals show real potential." Let the GM know that you're hoping for a follower, and they'll probably work with you.
- ⊙ Go to a bigger town and find a public place, like the Swap in Gordin's Delve or Edgemarket in Marshedge. Announce that you're looking to hire help. Say what the job is and what you're offering. Those towns each have a special player move for Recruiting.



Playbooks & Inserts



The Blessed
The Fox
The Heavy
The Judge
The Lightbearer
The Marshal
The Ranger
The Seeker
The Would-be Hero
Inserts
Ghost
Revenant
Thrall
Stonetop steading playbook